graceedge ministries
DEAD RAISERS

WORD CONFERENCE 2026



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Pastor Vwakpor Efuetanu | 2026

About Us

Grace Edge Ministries (Dead Raisers)

Founded in 2016 and led by Reverend Vwakpor Efuetanu, Dead Raisers is a movement rooted in the Spirit, sound teaching, and the power of the Holy Ghost. Driven by a dedicated workforce, leaders, and a robust chapel system, the ministry views service as a life poured out rather than a performance.

Expressions & Meetings

The ministry gathers for all biblical meeting types, categorized into:
Teaching Meetings: Weekly Dead Raisers Conferences, Word Conference, and This Gospel Seminar.
Prayer Meetings: Hotspot Conferences and Homecoming Conference.
Healing Meetings: Healing Meeting Series.
Evangelistic Meetings: Market Outreaches, Secondary School Outreaches, and Chapel Crusades.
Believers' Meetings: Holy Ghost Meetings.

Reach and Mandate

With a local, national, and global vision, the ministry carries the Gospel across Nigeria and internationally, holding crusades and establishing satellite churches in Ekiti, Agbor, Lagos, Russia, and Texas.

Foundation and Culture

Discipleship is structured around accountability, honour, and the Word, built upon six strong pillars:

1. Word and Prayer
2. Following

3. Honour
4. Giving
5. Brotherhood
6. Family Life

Ministry Arms & Training

The work is supported by diverse arms—including International and Local Missions, Institute of Dead Raisers Trainings, Satellite Churches, University and Secondary School groups, Media, Choir, Scribes, Finance, Logistics, Grace Edge Love Foundation, and Church on the Street, among others. Disciples are equipped through living practical tools like chapel growth manuals, tent-making manuals, and training guides to stand ready for missions and life.

WORD CONFERENCE 2026

The Chariots and the Horsemen

How to Read the Bible

Vwakpor Efuetanu
Lead Pastor, Grace Edge Ministry (Dead Raisers)

THE CHARIOTS AND THE HORSEMEN

Introduction

The Cry at the Jordan

There is a cry in the second book of Kings that I have never been able to shake off. Elisha is standing by the Jordan, watching his master taken from him. A chariot of fire and horses of fire come between the two men, and Elijah goes up by a whirlwind into heaven. And Elisha cries out:

> *"My father, my father, the chariot of Israel, and the horsemen thereof."*
>
> 2 KINGS 2:12

Read that again. Israel had kings. Israel had armies, walls, treaties and horses of its own. Yet when Elisha looked at the man being taken from him, he did not see an old prophet in a hairy cloak. He saw Israel's real defence. He understood that the strength of the nation had never been in its cavalry. It had been in a man who walked with God, and in the hosts of heaven that stood behind that man.

Years later, when Elisha himself lay dying, the king of Israel came and wept over him, and he used the very same words: "O my father, my father, the chariot of Israel, and the horsemen thereof" (2 Kings 13:14). Even a backslidden king knew where the nation's real strength lay. And when Elisha was dead and buried, a dead



man thrown into his tomb touched his bones and stood up alive (2 Kings 13:21). The power did not end when the prophet died.

That is the theme of this year's Word Conference: **The Chariots and the Horsemen.**

The Mountain Was Full

A few chapters on, the same Elisha is surrounded at Dothan. His servant rises early, sees the Syrian army ringing the city with horses and chariots, and panics: “Alas, my master! how shall we do?” Elisha's answer is one of the most unsettling sentences in the Bible:

> *“Fear not: for they that be with us are more than they that be with them.”*
>
> **2 KINGS 6:16**

Then Elisha prays, “LORD, I pray thee, open his eyes, that he may see.” And the LORD opened the eyes of the young man, “and he saw: and, behold, the mountain was full of horses and chariots of fire round about Elisha” (2 Kings 6:17).

Nothing on that mountain changed except the servant's eyes. The chariots were there before he saw them. They were there while he was panicking. The only question was whether he would see what was already true. That is the burden of this conference.

The World the Bible Takes for Granted

Let me say plainly what I have come to believe: much of the church reads the Bible with its eyes half shut. Many of us have been trained by a modern, Western, scientific mindset to treat the supernatural parts of Scripture as decoration, as poetry, or as something to be explained away. The writers of the Bible did no such thing. They lived in a world crowded with spiritual beings: the sons of God, the host of heaven, principalities and powers, the rulers of the darkness of this world. And they wrote as people who believed it.

Few scholars of our generation did more to recover this than the late Dr Michael S. Heiser. In his book *The Unseen Realm*, Heiser argued that if we want to understand the Bible, we have to read it the way its first readers did, through the eyes of an ancient Israelite, and not through the filter of the traditions we inherited. He drew our attention to passages most of us skip over.

Psalm 82 is one of them: “God has taken his place in the divine council; in the midst of the gods he holds judgment” (Psalm 82:1, ESV). Deuteronomy 32 is another. It tells us that when the Most High divided the nations, “he fixed the borders of the peoples according to the number of the sons of God,” but kept Israel as his own portion (Deuteronomy 32:8–9, ESV).

Heiser showed that this looks back to Babel, the very moment in these study notes where God scatters the corrupted human project. That scattering had an unseen side. From there, the story of the

Bible becomes a contest for the nations. It runs through Elijah on Carmel and Elisha at Dothan. It runs to the cross, where Christ "spoiled principalities and powers" and "made a shew of them openly" (Colossians 2:15). And it ends on the day when "the kingdoms of this world are become the kingdoms of our Lord, and of his Christ" (Revelation 11:15).

Heiser had a simple rule for reading Scripture that I want you to carry into every session: **if it's weird, it's important.** The strange passages are not the embarrassing corners of the Bible. Very often they are the doors into its centre.

Why We Begin with How to Read

So why would I open a conference on the unseen realm with sessions on how to read the Bible? Because you cannot see what the Bible sees until you learn to read the Bible the way it was written.

In the pages that follow, you will learn that the Bible is one unified story that leads to Jesus. You will learn that it is written as narrative, poetry and prose, and that each must be read on its own terms. You will learn that ancient Jewish writers left gaps on purpose, that every detail they included matters, and that Scripture is meant to be read slowly, aloud, day and night, until it begins to read you.

These are not academic tools. They are the means by which God opens the eyes of the young man on the mountain.

What I Am Asking of You

Come with your Bible open and your assumptions loose. Read these notes slowly. Read them aloud, the way Psalm 1 describes. Talk about them with the people around you. Wrestle with the hard passages instead of rushing past them.

And pray Elisha's prayer over your own life: *LORD, open my eyes, that I may see.*

I believe that by the end of this conference, some of you will look at your situation the way Elisha's servant looked at Dothan the second time. Not as someone surrounded by enemies, but as someone surrounded by heaven. They that be with us are more than they that be with them.

Welcome to Word Conference 2026.

Vwakpor Efuetanu
Lead Pastor, Grace Edge Ministry (Dead Raisers)

How to Read the Bible Overview

One Unified Story

Over these sessions, I am going to teach you how to read the Bible: how to understand its message and how to appreciate its unique literary design. The Bible is an intricate work of art. It tells one unified story, and that story leads to Jesus. But understand this from the outset: it is not like any book you have ever read.

What Do We Mean by Genre?

The Bible is a collection of books, and each one has its own purpose. And to make it more interesting, the Bible is not written in one particular literary style or genre. So what do I mean by genre? A genre is a unique style of communicating, and certain genres are more effective than others at communicating certain ideas or stories.

A news article is one genre. A children's book is another. Each genre has its own techniques and rules that writers use to communicate. The Bible has three main literary styles: narrative, poetry and prose.

What We Will Cover

In these sessions, I will unpack the important elements of each of the Bible's literary styles as we walk through key sections of the Bible together. The Bible is a large book, but it does not have to be intimidating. By the end, you will see that the Bible is divinely inspired literature that leads us to Jesus.

What is the Bible?

One of the Most Influential Books

The Bible is one of the most influential books in human history. It explores the big questions of why we exist.

It has inspired many people to do amazing things, and it has confused many others. And most of you have one sitting somewhere at home.

A Small Library from Ancient Israel

So what is the Bible, actually? The Bible is a small library of books, and all of them emerged out of the history of the people of ancient Israel. In one sense, Israel was just like any other ancient civilisation. But among them was a long line of individuals called prophets.

The prophets viewed Israel's story as anything but ordinary. They saw it as a central part of what God was doing for all humanity. And these prophets were literary geniuses.

They expertly crafted the Hebrew language to write epic narratives and very sophisticated poetry. They were masters of metaphor and storytelling. And they used all of this to explore life's most complicated questions about death and life and the human struggle.

Written Over a Thousand Years

So the Bible has many different authors, and these texts were produced over a thousand-year period, beginning with Israel's origins in Egypt.

From there, the story leads up to their kingdom and their first temple. Eventually they were conquered by the Babylonians, who carried them away into exile. Then, at a crucial moment in their history, many Israelites returned to their land.

The Tanakh

They built a second temple and reformed their identity. It was at this point that the Jewish scriptures began to be formed into the shape we have them in today. So what is in the Jewish Bible? In Hebrew, it is called by an acronym: Tanakh.

The T stands for Torah, sometimes called the Law. That is Israel's five-book foundation story. The N stands for Nevi'im, the Hebrew word for prophets.

This section consists of the historical books that tell Israel's story from the prophets' point of view, followed by the poetic books of the prophets themselves. The K stands for Ketuvim, the Hebrew word for writings.

This is a diverse collection of poetic books, wisdom books and more narrative. The Jewish people believed that through all of these literary works, God speaks to his people. Now, there were

other Jewish writings produced during this Second Temple period as well.

It was a really diverse group of texts, and these too were highly valued in Jewish communities. From ancient times there was debate about whether some of them should be considered part of the Scriptures.

Why Put Them Together?

So why, over such a long period of time, were all these writings put together like this? Because together these texts tell an epic story about how God is working through this people to bring order and beauty out of the chaos of our world. And it all builds up to a hope for a new leader who would come and renew all creation.

And then the Tanakh concludes, and this leader never comes. It is an expertly crafted work, but it is missing an ending. A few centuries later, a Jewish prophet named Jesus of Nazareth comes onto the scene.

He claimed that he was carrying the Tanakh story forward. Jesus did remarkable things, and he was killed, but his followers declared that he was alive from the dead. They said that Jesus was that long-awaited leader who would restore the world.

The Writings of the Apostles

His earliest followers, called apostles, composed new literary works about the story of Jesus. They called these the Good News, or

the Gospel. They wrote an account called Acts about the spread of the Jesus movement outside of Israel.

They also circulated letters to Jesus communities all around the ancient world, and they saw these writings as part of Scripture. The apostles wrote all of this as the fulfilment of the epic story found in the Tanakh.

They were continuing the literary genius of the Jewish tradition. And they believed that God was speaking to his people through these texts, alongside the scriptures of Israel. That is the Old and New Testament.

The Other Second Temple Literature

So what did the early Christians think of the other Second Temple literature? Different groups held different views about some of these books, but we know they read them and valued them, because they passed them along with the Jewish scriptures.

So we have the Tanakh, the Jewish scriptures. We have the other Second Temple works. And we have the writings of the apostles about Jesus. That is a lot of literature.

What Is in Your Bible?

So what is in your Bible? The Christian movement has taken different forms over 2,000 years. From the beginning, all Christians recognised the Tanakh and the New Testament as Scripture. For centuries, much of the Second Temple literature was read as part

of the biblical tradition. The Catholic Church eventually made it official and called some of the books from this collection the Deuterocanonical books.

Some Orthodox churches used even more books from this Second Temple literature. Then in the 1500s, during the Reformation, Protestant Christians wanted to go back to the oldest writings of the prophets and apostles, so they accepted only the Old and New Testaments.

That brings us to the question I want you to hold on to: how does a collection of books, produced over 1,000 years by so many different authors, tell one unified story?

The Story of the Bible • What It's About From Beginning to End

God and Creation

The Bible is an important book, and it is really long. It is a collection of many books written over a long period of time, but together they tell one unified story. So what is the story of the Bible? It begins by introducing us to a beautiful mind, the author of all reality, a being called God.

He has the power to take the dark chaos of the uncreated world and bring about order and beauty and a garden full of life. And to crown this accomplishment, God appoints creatures called humanity, or in Hebrew, Adam. They are made as God's image.

This means they are commissioned to rule this beautiful world on God's behalf, by harnessing all of its potential and creating even more beauty and order. This is a story about humans using their power to do meaningful, life-giving work. But the question is, how? Humanity now faces a choice, and it is represented by a fruit tree.

The Choice

Humans could partner with God and find freedom by trusting in his knowledge of good and evil. Or they could seize power and define good and evil on their own, which, God warns, will kill them. Then they hear the voice of a dark, mysterious creature that tells them the choice is simple: take the fruit.

It will give you power and freedom to rule the world on your own terms, it says. So they seize this knowledge, and as a result they become suspicious and self-protective. It leads to fractured relationships, violent power grabs, and ultimately a whole civilisation, Babylon, that has redefined evil as good.

Abraham and Sarah

So God scatters this corrupted human project. And here the story of the Bible takes an important turn. We zoom in on the story of a man and a woman who come out of Babylon: Abraham and Sarah.

God promises that from them will come a new people, a nation that has another chance to make the right choice. If they succeed, it will open up a new way forward for the rest of humanity. This is why the rest of the Bible's story is about this family.

Israel Fails

And it does not go well. Despite God's personal guidance, Abraham's family gives in to that same temptation to redefine good and evil on their own terms, apart from God. Even when their best

people were in charge, rulers who loved God's guidance and had divine wisdom, even they gave in.

So Israel was warned by their own prophets that these choices would lead them back to Babylon, this time as conquered captives living in exile. And that is exactly what happened. Even with God's personal guidance, Israel fails.

A Promise Left Hanging

So who can succeed? The prophets said the story was not over. God was going to send a new leader to Israel to cover for their failures and to transform the people's hearts and minds so that they could make the right choice. And so the part of the Bible called the Old Testament ends, and these promises are left hanging.

Jesus of Nazareth

Then the biblical story continues into the New Testament. We are introduced to a man who comes from the line of Israel's kings, Jesus of Nazareth. He said that he was bringing all these promises to their completion.

He confronted the dark, mysterious evil that all humanity has given in to, and he resisted its power. Then he announced that God had arrived to rule the world through him. Jesus taught about God's definition of good and evil.

He said that real power is serving others. According to Jesus, it is the people who love the poor and even love their enemies who actually rule the world.

That is confusing, but it is also really beautiful. And so is the claim the story goes on to make about Jesus: that he is God become human, to be for Israel and for all humanity what we could never be for ourselves. He came to take the consequences of our evil into himself.

And his sacrificial love proved more powerful than evil, and even than death itself. So now humanity is presented with a new choice, represented by a new tree.

Stick with the old way of being human, or venture into this new way. In the story, those who choose the way of Jesus find themselves energised by God's own power. People who know that they are loved and forgiven by God can become people who love and forgive others in return.

The Jesus Movement

The Jesus movement quickly spread throughout the world, forming new communities of people who follow the way of Jesus. But they faced problems.

There was persecution from the outside, by people in power. And inside there was confusion, even compromise, because following Jesus is really hard.

So the movement's leaders, called apostles, wrote letters to comfort and to challenge these communities to stay faithful to the difficult way of Jesus. And they called them to hope for the day when Jesus will come and change everything.

How the Story Ends

And so the Bible ends by pointing to the future day when all wrongs are made right, when evil is eradicated, heaven and earth are united, and humanity can rule the world together in the love and power of God. That is the story of the Bible.

It brings all of these books together. But what is interesting is that each book contains a different kind of literature that contributes to this story in a unique way.

Writing Styles of the Bible & Why They're Important to Understand

Different Literary Styles

The Bible is a collection of many books, telling one unified story from beginning to end. But all those books were written in different literary styles. Think of it like walking into a bookshop where every aisle holds a different kind of literature.

There is history, there is poetry, there is non-fiction. When you choose an aisle and pick up a book, you have very different expectations; you are looking for different things. They are all literature, but they communicate in really different ways.

The same is true of the Bible. If you do not pay attention to the style it is written in, you will miss the brilliance of each book.

The Main Types of Literature

So what are the main types of literature in the Bible? First and foremost is narrative. It makes up a whopping 43% of the Bible.

After that is poetry, which is 33% of the Bible. And then there is what we call prose discourse, which makes up the remaining 24%.

Narrative

Nearly half the Bible is narrative, and this is no accident. Stories are the most universal form of human communication.

Our brains are hardwired to take in information through stories, and stories are enjoyable. Why? Because stories train us to make sense of the seemingly random events of life by taking those events and putting them in a sequence.

Put together, you begin to see the meaning and purpose of it all. And what links it all together? Good stories always have a character who wants something. Through these characters, an author can explore life's big questions, like who we are, or what is really important in life.

A good story always involves some kind of conflict, some challenge to overcome, just as in our own lives. That forces us to think about our own challenges, why there is so much pain and disappointment in the world, and what we can do about it.

Stories usually end with some kind of resolution, giving us hope for our own stories. Now, since these are Bible stories, you might think the characters are showing you how you should live. That is not quite the point. Most Bible characters are deeply flawed.

You should not be like them. But you are supposed to see yourself in them, and that helps you see your life and your failures from a

new perspective. Without even realising it, these stories will start to work on you and change how you see the world, other people and yourself.

There are different types of narrative in the Bible: historical narrative, narrative parables, and short biographical narratives like the four Gospels. We will look at all of these in later sessions.

Poetry

Next is poetry. Many of you honestly do not read much poetry, and you are like most people. But one out of every three chapters in the Bible is poetry.

Why so much poetry? Poems speak mainly through dense, creative language, linking images together to help us envision the world differently. Poems use lots of metaphor to stir your emotions and your imagination.

You may ask, wouldn't it be easier just to tell me what I need to know? Think about it. In life we form mental ruts. We think along familiar, well-worn paths that are very hard to get out of through logic or reasoning. What good poetry does is force you off the familiar path and into new territory.

There are different types of poetry in the Bible. There are many kinds of songs, or psalms. There is the reflective poetry of the wisdom books. And there is the passionate resistance poetry of the prophets.

Prose Discourse

The last major literary type is called prose discourse, and it makes up a quarter of the Bible. These are speeches, letters and essays. The focus here is building a sequence of ideas or thoughts into one linear argument that requires a logical response.

It sounds like this: Have you thought about this? You should also consider how it connects to this other thing. If you do, you will see that this is the result. And in light of that conclusion, you should stop doing that one thing, so that this other thing will be the outcome.

Discourse persuades you with reason. It forces you to think logically and consistently, and then to do something about it. Biblical discourse is found in the law collections, in wisdom literature and in the letters written by the apostles.

Books With More Than One Style

Now, does each book of the Bible have only one literary style? No. Most books have a primary literary style, narrative for example. But embedded in that narrative, you will come across poems, parables or a collection of laws.

Every biblical book is a unique combination of literary styles. To read a book well, you need to be familiar with each literary type and how it works, so that you know what to pay attention to and what questions to ask.

But before we look at each type, there is one more unifying feature of biblical literature that is really important. That is what we will explore next.

How the Bible Is Unique as Literature (and Why It Matters)

Literature from a Time and Place

The Bible is a collection of books written in different literary styles: narrative, poetry and prose. Most of us are familiar with these kinds of literature. We all know a narrative when we see one, like The Hunger Games or The Great Gatsby.

Most people can recognise poetry, whether it is Walt Whitman or the songs of Bob Dylan. And every day we are surrounded by prose in news articles and essays. All of these examples are modern American literature; they came from a particular time and region of the world.

But there is also medieval English literature from another place and time, and ancient Greek writing from another. Every time period and culture produces its own unique kind of literature. To read the Bible well, we must keep in mind that it comes from a

particular part of the world and was produced in a particular period of time.

Every Detail Matters

So what is unique about ancient Jewish literature? A key feature is that it lacks many of the details modern readers have come to expect in stories and poems. That makes it seem really simple. But it is actually very sophisticated literature.

Every detail that is given matters. But the lack of detail means that the stories are often loaded with ambiguities.

Take one of the first stories, Adam and Eve in the garden. Where did this talking snake come from? Why did God allow him there? Why didn't Adam and Eve die on the spot, as God said they would? And who is this offspring of the woman who will destroy the snake but is bitten by it? There are so many puzzles in this story. Some of them are our questions, and they are not important to what the author is focusing on.

Intentional Ambiguities

But some of these ambiguities are intentional. You may ask: won't that lead to bad interpretations, with people filling the gaps with their own answers? That is a risk the biblical authors took in writing this way. We all tend to impose our own cultural assumptions onto the Bible.

But they clearly thought the risk was worth it. These oddities are invitations into an adventure of reading and discovery. Let me show you what I mean with that strange promise about the offspring of the woman crushing the snake and being bitten by it.

Following the Offspring

The word offspring is a clue to pay attention to the genealogies, and they run all through the biblical narrative. They trace the lineage from Eve all the way to King David and his offspring. In the New Testament, Jesus is connected to the offspring of this royal line.

When you read the prophets, Isaiah connects this king to the suffering servant who would die on behalf of his people. Then in the book of Revelation there is a symbolic vision, and it is about a woman and her offspring.

It is Jesus and his followers, who conquer the dragon by giving up their lives. Each part of that story is loaded with ambiguities. But all together, it makes sense.

A Lifetime of Reading

This is the literary genius of the Bible. It forces you to keep reading and to interpret each part in light of the others.

You may feel this is complicated and wonder whether you can do all that. You are not expected to notice all of this by yourself, or all at once. This dense way of writing forces you to slow down and

read carefully, embarking on an interactive process of discovery through the whole biblical narrative, over a lifetime of reading and rereading.

Meditation Literature

This is meditation literature. In Psalm 1, we read about the ideal Bible reader: someone who meditates on the Scriptures day and night. In Hebrew, the word meditate literally means to mutter, or to speak quietly. The idea is that every day, for the rest of your life, you slowly and quietly read the Bible aloud to yourself.

Then you go and talk about it with your friends, pondering the puzzles, making connections and discovering what it all means. And as you let the Bible interpret itself, something remarkable happens. The Bible starts to read you.

Because ultimately, the writers of the Bible want you to adopt this story as your story. This ancient Jewish way of writing creates its own unique types of narrative, poetry and discourse, and we will explore each of these literary styles, starting next with biblical narrative.

Plot in Biblical Narrative

What Is a Plot?

We are learning how to read the different types of literature in the Bible, and we are going to start with biblical narrative. Narratives, in their most basic form, have characters in a setting going through a series of events. How those events are selected and then arranged by an author is called the plot.

A basic plot line begins with a character in her setting. Then something new or unexpected happens, causing problems that build up to some ultimate conflict. That conflict is then resolved, and the character finds herself changed, living in a new normal. Now, when you read narratives, it is important to understand every scene in the context of its larger plot line. You can make the same story carry a totally different message if you ignore where it occurs in the plot.

Gideon and the Fleece

This happens all the time when people read the Bible. Take the story of Gideon. There is a well-known scene where Gideon is trying to discern whether God will help him win a battle, and he asks God for a sign.

Gideon lays a wool fleece on the ground and asks that in the morning the fleece be wet with dew but the ground completely dry, and God does it. Now, if you look at this scene by itself, what is the conflict? How can Gideon know if he will succeed? And the resolution? Test God, ask for a sign, and find out. That is how many people actually read this story, and it completely misses the point, because it ignores the larger plot line.

Reading the Whole Story

So let us start from the beginning, and you will get the context. The story begins with Gideon and the Israelites living in fear, because they are oppressed by an invading people, the Midianites.

Then comes the call to action. God commissions Gideon to defeat the Midianites and save Israel.

This is shaping up to be a good story. But Gideon is extremely hesitant, so he asks God for a sign: so I can know it is really you talking to me. And God stoops to his level.

He gives him a sign by lighting a fire on an altar. So Gideon has already asked for a sign. And that is not all.

In the next scene, God tells Gideon to tear down an altar to another god, but Gideon is so afraid that he does it at night. So Gideon is sceptical, and also a bit of a coward. Then we come to the moment when Gideon is about to face the Midianites, and he is still uncertain, so he asks for another sign: the fleece.

He says, I want to know if you will save Israel by my hand. God gives him that sign. And he is still uncertain, so he asks for one more sign, which is just a variation of the previous one.

Gideon is asking for far too many signs. In the larger context, it is clear that the conflict of the plot is not, how can Gideon discern the mysterious will of God? The real conflict is, when will this man get his act together and start trusting God? So what is the resolution? We have to keep reading.

The Resolution

Gideon gathers a huge army, 30,000 soldiers, to fight the Midianites, and God says no, that is far too many men. He whittles the army down to 300. Why would he do that? Because Gideon has been testing God, and now God returns the favour.

He tells Gideon to arm these 300 soldiers with trumpets and torches, surround the Midianites at night, and make a great deal of noise in the hills. It sounds ridiculous, but Gideon does it. And the noise throws the Midianites into a frenzy. They start destroying each other in the dark, while Gideon looks on safely from the hills.

So this story is not offering you tips for discerning God's will. It is about God's commitment to use weak people with deep flaws to do more than they could ever have imagined. Short scenes like Gideon and the fleece are combined with other scenes to make up a larger plot line.

Layers of Plot

Tracing the conflict and resolution through the plot helps you see the message the author is trying to get across. Now, Gideon's story has been set alongside many other stories that are also about flawed, often questionable leaders called judges. Each of these has its own internal plot line.

But all together, they make up a whole movement of the biblical story, the period of the judges, and that movement has its own unified plot line. There are many movements within the story of the Bible, and all the smaller stories, hundreds of them, fit within the context of their own movements.

These movements together make up the building blocks of the grand plot line of the whole story of the Bible. So no matter where you are reading in the Bible, you need to pay attention to these different layers of plot so that you read each story in its context.

The Bible is a sophisticated piece of literature. All these smaller plot lines keep overlapping and building up the tension. And when you step back, you can see how they have all been woven together into the unified story that leads to Jesus.

Character in Biblical Narrative

Characters as a Mirror

We are talking about how to read biblical narrative, in other words, how to read stories. One of the main ingredients of any good story is characters who encounter conflict and then have to overcome it. So let us talk about characters.

In most stories, we quickly identify with the characters, because just like them, we are in our own story with our own conflicts to overcome. Good stories have characters with relatable struggles. We watch them react to their challenges in different ways, and we get to see what happens as a result.

Through characters, an author can show us their view of what it means to be human. The Bible is no different. Biblical stories use characters as a mirror, so that we can see ourselves and discover our own human nature in the reflection.

Saying Much with Little

Now, characters in the Bible can be hard to relate to, because very little detail is often given about them. Biblical authors develop characters differently from modern narratives.

They prefer to communicate a lot through minimal detail. For example, we rarely hear what people look like in the Bible, but when we do, it is crucially important to the story. We are told that Saul is tall and that David was something of a runt.

These become images of their moral character. Saul's height matches his love of status and of power to impose authority, while David humbly accepts his low status and allows God to exalt and deliver him. People's physical appearances are very often symbolic.

Esau's hairy body fits his animal-like behaviour, and Jacob's smooth skin matches his deceptive, slippery nature. What other clues do we get about biblical characters? Often, people's names symbolise their role in the story.

Abraham in Hebrew sounds like “father of a multitude.” Jacob means “deceiver.” Ruth means “refreshment.”

And Saul's name means “the one asked for.” He is the flawed king the people requested. By packing all this meaning into very little detail, biblical stories do a great deal in a small space.

No Moral Commentary

They even leave out things modern readers want to know about these characters. They rarely come out and tell us people's thoughts or motives. When Moses saw an Egyptian beating an Israelite, he killed him on the spot.

But why? Was this righteous anger, or did he simply lose his temper? And was God okay with what he did? We are not told,

because biblical authors usually avoid giving moral commentary. They would rather let a character's words and actions reveal their motives, and then leave us to judge their behaviour by seeing the consequences.

In the case of Moses, this murder is the beginning of a pattern of his anger getting the better of him, with bad results. This choice forces him to run and hide in the desert for 40 years. So it was a bad thing.

But out there he meets his wife. So is it a good thing? Exactly. It forces you to ponder.

Through all these techniques, the biblical narrators keep their stories compact and memorable, but also engaging. So was Moses good or bad? In classic stories, there is always a good guy and a bad guy, some admirable hero who faces off against some horrible villain.

Complex People, Faithful God

Simplified characters like that are helpful for teaching children that there is such a thing as good and evil. But the Bible is not a children's book. Its characters are very complex, a mixed bag of good and evil, just like us.

There are hardly any flawless characters in the Bible. What about heroes of the faith like Abraham or King David? Do you mean Abraham, who used an Egyptian slave for sex and then lied about his wife twice to save his own neck? Or David, the man after God's

own heart, who slept with another man's wife and then murdered him? These stories are anything but simplistic. They offer us realistic portraits of compromised people like ourselves.

The real surprise is that God keeps working with them despite their failures. So just because a person is called by God, wins a battle, or becomes successful or wealthy, it does not mean the biblical author wants you to act like them. In fact, it would be very dangerous to imitate most biblical characters.

But there is something admirable in biblical characters, something you can imitate. Pay attention, and you will notice that most biblical stories highlight the moments when characters fail or come to the end of themselves, and then choose radical trust in God's grace and wisdom.

It is in these stories that the authors show us how to be a human who truly pleases God, through humility and surrender. The fact that God stays committed to biblical characters is a profound statement about the patience and love of God, who is also a character in the story. By studying biblical characters, we observe our own worst tendencies on display, and we see, time and again, God's gracious response that will see this story through to the end.

Setting in Biblical Narrative

Settings Create Expectations

In every story you have ever heard, the action took place somewhere. That place is called the setting. Since we have been learning how to read biblical narratives, let us talk about how settings work in the Bible.

Settings are a crucially important tool in the hands of the biblical authors. Think of it this way. When you start a story, everything is new.

The plot and the characters are a mystery until things unfold. We have no idea what to expect, except that authors can use the setting of a story to prepare you for what is coming.

Let us say a story begins in a courtroom. What do you expect? A story about crime and justice. Or take the setting of a dark, old, rundown house. You expect something frightening is about to happen.

Settings evoke memories and emotions because of other stories you know that happened in similar places. Authors know this, and they use settings to generate expectations about what could happen in this story.

A good author will get creative with settings and play with your expectations in order to make a point. This happens all over the Bible. For example, think about Egypt as a setting in the Bible: the great Middle Eastern empire on the Nile. Now think about the first biblical story in which someone ends up in Egypt.

Egypt: The Place of Trouble

It is about Abraham. God calls him to journey by faith to a new land, and promises to give him a huge family. So he sets out, but he arrives during a famine.

Now, is he going to trust God and stay in the promised land, or will he leave the land and look for food on his own? Abraham leaves and goes down to Egypt. And there in Egypt, things go downhill fast. Abraham denies that Sarah is his wife to save his own neck, and Pharaoh tries to marry her himself.

So our first impression of Egypt is that it is not a good place to visit. But God rescues them. He strikes Egypt with plagues, and Pharaoh relents and sends Abraham away with loads of wealth.

So what do we learn about Egypt as a setting from this story? It is the place people end up because of foolish decisions, but it is also a place where God comes and rescues his people. The next main story in Egypt follows the same pattern. Abraham's great-grandsons make a series of foolish choices, and these eventually lead them to Egypt because of another famine.

Down in Egypt, generations pass, and the family ends up as slaves. And what do you expect to happen? God is going to send plagues and rescue his people.

After the Israelites get back to the promised land, God tells them never to go back to Egypt for any reason. It is the place of trouble and oppression.

So when later biblical characters go to Egypt, you are supposed to cringe. Take Solomon. At the peak of his wealth and power, he married the daughter of the king of Egypt, and then he started sending Israelites there to import Egyptian stallions.

A generation later, that alliance goes bad, and Egypt oppresses Israel all over again. So biblical settings carry the memories of previous stories, and those memories create expectation.

When the Author Flips the Setting

It is a brilliant literary device to fill stories with meaning. The biblical authors are brilliant. They can build up your expectations, but they can also creatively overturn them.

Egypt is a perfect example. In the Gospel of Matthew, when Jesus is born, his family flees to Egypt. You would think this is a problem.

But pay attention. Instead of Egypt being the bad place, it is the place of safety. Because who are they fleeing from? King Herod, who is behaving exactly as Pharaoh did, but he rules Jerusalem, not Egypt.

Matthew is showing you that Jerusalem has become Egypt. You can find patterns like these in many different biblical settings.

Situations and Time as Settings

Babylon, Moab, the wilderness, Bethlehem: the list goes on. And it gets bigger, because sometimes the setting is not just a place on a map.

It is a type of situation, but it works the same way settings do. For example, when people move toward the east, expect trouble. Adam and Eve were banished to the east, and then Cain wanders to the east.

People move to the east to build Babylon. And all of these narratives are designed to point forward to the time when the Israelites as a people will be exiled to the east, in Babylon.

That leads to one more type of setting in biblical narrative, and that is time, or how long events take. Periods of 40 are often associated with stories in which people's faithfulness is tested. Noah is in the boat for 40 days and 40 nights.

Then he gets off and gets completely drunk. The Israelites grew impatient during their 40 days of waiting for Moses on Mount Sinai, so they made the golden calf. After the Israelite spies investigate the land for 40 days, the people rebel, so they have to wander in the desert for 40 years.

But then there is the story of Jesus, who was tested in the desert for 40 days, and he reverses the expectation. He overcomes the test.

Across the whole Bible, places, situations and time periods become full of meaning by evoking memories and setting expectations. And the New Testament authors reuse all of these settings to show how Jesus is the one carrying our world from the garden, out of Egypt and the wilderness, and into the new creation.

Design Patterns in Biblical Narrative

What Are Design Patterns?

We have been exploring how biblical narratives work, and stories in the Bible are like any other story. You have to pay attention to the characters, the setting and the plot.

These are the basic tools an author uses to help readers see the meaning and significance of events. Now it is time to learn one final skill that brings all these elements together: how to detect design patterns in biblical narrative. What do I mean by design patterns? The biblical authors have shaped all these elements, character, setting and plot, to create a series of repeated patterns that weave through story after story and tie them all together.

When you notice these patterns, you will see how different stories across the whole Bible have been coordinated to emphasise key themes. So how do you find a biblical pattern? The biblical authors do it subtly. The best way to catch on is to watch them embed key words and images that link stories together.

The Temptation Pattern

Take one of the main themes of the Bible, the complex and tragic human condition. Let us start at the beginning, where God is making a very good world.

Seven times it says God saw that it was good. Those are clearly important words. Now watch.

God appoints two characters, whose names mean human and life, to rule this world on his behalf, and they are told that everything is good for them to eat, except the tree of knowing good and evil. Then the humans doubt God, and in Genesis we read that they see that it is good to take this knowledge for themselves.

Then we read that they desire to become wise. And finally, they take what they want. And everything falls apart.

This story is about the human condition, and on its own it is a powerful story. But the biblical authors do not leave it there.

They turn it into a pattern. It happens again with Abraham and Sarah. God brings them into the promised land and promises them a child.

But they do not trust God. They grow impatient, and we read the same words. They see their Egyptian slave.

They take her and do what is good in their eyes. The stories match. Then you get to Aaron at Mount Sinai, and we read how he sees and then takes the gold of the Israelites to make the golden calf.

There is the story of Achan, who sees the gold of the Canaanites. He desires it and takes it for himself. This pattern highlights how one person's temptation can create suffering for many people.

It is just like the story of Saul, where we read that the Israelites see him, desire him and take him as their king, so that they can be like all the other nations.

And Saul's reign leads them to destruction. Then there is the story of David, which says that he sees Bathsheba, desires her, takes her, and then kills her husband.

And then David's family starts destroying each other. So you see, it is one basic theme repeated over and over. These stories are all designed to show the temptation pattern.

Jesus Breaks the Pattern

That may sound bleak. But the repetition builds up anticipation. Perhaps someone will come and break the pattern.

This is why the stories of Jesus have been designed to carry the patterns forward to their climax. What does Jesus say when he faces his greatest temptation, to avoid dying on the cross? Not my desire, but your desire be done. The pattern flips, and you have one person resisting temptation, and his suffering provides life for many.

Through the Waters into a New World

Let me give you one more, a big one: how God brings humanity through chaotic waters into a new world.

It starts on page one, where God separates the dark, chaotic waters. Dry land emerges as a home for humans to flourish. Then the pattern reappears with the chaotic waters of the flood.

God rescues a remnant, Noah and his family, through the waters so that they can step onto dry land and become humanity 2.0. Does that basic storyline remind you of anything else? The famous Exodus story.

That is when God saves his chosen people from Egypt by leading them through the waters onto dry land, while Pharaoh and his army are destroyed. The pattern repeats later with Joshua and the Israelites.

They pass through the waters of the Jordan into the promised land. Now you can see how later biblical authors project this pattern into the future.

Isaiah hoped for a new Exodus, with a new king leading God's people forward into a new creation. And in this repetition, the nations become the chaotic waters.

You can see how combining all these patterns brings us to Jesus. Notice how all the Gospels highlight the story of Jesus going to the Jordan River. He goes into the waters and back out again.

His baptism. That is when God announces that Jesus is his Son, who will rescue the world from the chaos of our evil and violence by going into death and out the other side. This is why baptism became such a big deal for Jesus' followers.

It is about participating in this ancient pattern: going through the waters of death and following Jesus into the new creation.

Why Patterns Matter

These design patterns are the main way the biblical authors have unified hundreds of stories together. And every pattern develops a core theme throughout the whole biblical story that leads to Jesus. That is biblical narrative, which makes up over 40% of the Bible.

Another 30% is made up of ancient poetry. And learning to read biblical poetry is what we will explore next.

Metaphor in Biblical Poetry

We Think in Metaphors

We are learning how to read biblical poetry, which makes up over 30% of the Bible. Poetry is a way of writing that does not just communicate information. It invites us to experience ideas with our imaginations, using creative imagery, or what we would call metaphorical language.

So let us talk about imagery and metaphor in biblical poetry. Some things in life are easy to understand because they are tangible, physical experiences, like being cold. Being cold is no fun.

But other experiences are not as concrete, like when somebody does not like you. That is no fun either. These are two very different things.

But notice how your mind has linked them together without you knowing it. We say things like, she gave me the cold shoulder, or, don't be so cold. You can also flip it around and think of affection as warmth.

It took him a while to warm up to me. She is a warm person. We take a basic concept like warmth and map it onto an abstract concept like affection.

It gives us a more imaginative way to talk about our experiences. We are thinking in metaphors. They provide the framework for how our minds make sense of the world.

Metaphors govern all of our thinking and language. Even that phrase, metaphors govern, is a metaphor in itself; it says that ideas are rulers.

Or think about a connected metaphor: that competing ideas are at war. In a debate, I have to defend my position and provide backup so I can win the argument. So you can see that metaphors are not just a fancy way of writing.

They are everywhere in our language. And the metaphors we use shape our imaginations and our behaviour. So it is no surprise that the biblical poets constantly use metaphorical imagery.

Chaotic Waters

Some metaphors in the Bible are easy to understand, like light is good and darkness is bad. But remember, the biblical poets lived in an ancient culture, which means some of their metaphors may seem strange to us.

Picture chaotic water, like a deep, stormy ocean. Now think about a time you were in danger, and map those two onto each other. Danger is like chaotic waters.

The biblical authors take it further. They also talk about dangerous people as stormy waters.

In Psalm 69: “Save me, O God, for the waters are up to my throat. I have entered the deep waters. My enemies outnumber the hairs on my head.”

The enemies are dangerous waves. And so are enemy nations. In Isaiah 17: “Woe to the nations that rage like the raging, roaring seas.”

Or in Psalm 89: “O Lord, you rule the swelling seas. You scatter enemies with your mighty arm.” This is a basic metaphor for danger and chaos in our world.

But God has power over the chaotic waters. And this foundational image is so important.

It is introduced on page one of the Bible. The uncreated world in Genesis 1 is a dark, chaotic ocean that God brings order to.

The image begins there and then develops throughout the rest of the Bible. And so does its opposite.

Dry Land, the Garden and the Rock

If chaotic water is a fundamental image of danger, think about what dry land represents: safety, security, stability.

These are some of the most basic human desires. And that is what God is providing when the dry land appears in the opening pages of Genesis. This is also where God plants the Garden of Eden.

And it is no ordinary garden. It is described with the imagery of an ancient temple, high above those dangerous waters. From this garden temple flows a river that waters everything.

So the human ideal is to be with God in a mountain garden temple. This image permeates biblical poetry.

David celebrates God's presence in the temple in Psalm 65: “How blessed is the one who is satisfied with goodness in your temple. A stream of God waters the land.

You still the roaring of the waves and the turmoil of the nations.” Now watch. Because the temple was associated with being close to God's presence, this high rock could become a metaphor for God himself.

In Psalm 18: “The Lord is my rock and my fortress and my deliverer.” That is the image Jesus is drawing on when he says that listening to him is like building your house on the rock.

Notice how these rich metaphors in biblical poetry are rooted in images from earlier biblical narratives. That is how metaphors work in the Bible.

You need the narratives to understand the poetic images, and the images reveal deeper meaning in those narratives. And the largest collection of poetry in the Bible is the book of Psalms.

The Book of Psalms

Not an Ordinary Collection

We have been talking about poetry in the Bible: how biblical poets love design and masterfully use metaphor and symbolism. These poems invite us into an experience, to ponder ideas slowly and from many angles. The largest collection of poetry in the Bible is the book of Psalms.

So that is what we are going to look at now. The Israelites composed a great deal of poetry throughout their history. Poems were written by Israelites, sages, kings and prophets.

Some poems were sung by choirs in the Jerusalem temple, while others were prayed by families at home. Over the centuries, the most important and widely read poems were compiled together to be read or sung on special occasions. Most of us are familiar with books of poetry: a large collection of the greatest poems in one place, where you read through and pick your favourites.

But the book of Psalms is not that kind of collection. Here, each poem has been expertly crafted and then placed where it is for a reason, to create a storyline from the book's beginning to its end. The Psalms poetically retell the entire biblical story, and they invite you into a literary temple.

A Literary Temple

What do I mean by a literary temple? The tabernacle, and later the temple in Jerusalem, were where ancient Israelites went to meet with God. When you arrived, you would see art and imagery everywhere. You would see priests performing rituals, and you would hear songs and prayers.

All of it symbolically proclaimed that your God rules the world from this mountain, and you are in his living room. The temple was a place to be in God's presence, and also to immerse yourself in the story of God's kingdom.

Now try to imagine how traumatic it was when the Babylonians invaded Jerusalem, plundered and burned the temple, and then took many Israelites into exile. Where could they go now to meet with God, to sing their story and say their prayers? That is where the book of Psalms comes in. It is a prayer book for exiles, designed as a virtual temple.

You enter the Psalms to meet with God, and to hear the entire biblical story of God's kingdom sung back to you in poetry. So how do the Psalms do it? Let us start with the book's design. There are 150 poems, broken up into five clear sections.

Psalms 1 and 2: The Introduction

At the beginning, a short introduction has been placed, Psalms 1 and 2, which lays out the main themes of the whole book by

reviewing the biblical storyline. Psalm 1 looks back to the Garden of Eden and its river of life.

God placed humanity in a garden temple, and there humans decided to define good and evil on their own terms, and so were exiled from the garden. But the first Psalm paints a portrait of hope: an upright human who delights in God's wisdom, which is called Torah, or instruction.

This person is like the tree of life in the garden temple. They eternally blossom, because they are planted in the river of God's life. That is beautiful, but who is it supposed to be? Remember the story in Genesis.

After humanity's foolish rebellion, God made a promise: a future human, the seed of the woman, who would come and defeat evil and restore the world. And that is what Psalm 2 is about.

It is God's promise that a king would come from the line of David. He is called the Son of God and the Messiah. God appoints him to bring justice on human evil and to restore God's kingdom and peace over the nations.

The Five Sections

So Psalms 1 and 2 introduce all these main themes, and the book then develops them through the five sections.

The first two explore the complicated story of David and his royal family. The third section focuses on the tragedy of Israel's exile and the downfall of David's royal line. But then the fourth and fifth

sections rekindle the hope for the Messiah, a new temple and God's kingdom on the other side of the exile.

Then the book ends with a five-part conclusion praising God for his faithfulness.

David, the Prayer Coach

Nearly half of the Psalms are connected to one man, King David, whom God chose to rule Israel.

David's story is very important in this book. He experienced many times of hardship, but he trusted God with radical faith. In these poems, David shares his fears, confesses his failures and offers thanks to his Redeemer.

And he constantly speaks of a deep longing to be in God's presence in the temple. But David lived before the temple was even built.

This portrait of David, hoping and praying for God's kingdom and a future temple, resembles the hopes of the later generations of exiles. And so David's prayers could become theirs as well. David is like a prayer coach, giving us words for how to pray and how to discover God's presence in good times and bad.

There are 73 poems connected to David, but most of the rest come from later generations of biblical poets, who learned to pray and hope like David.

The end result is the book of Psalms, designed as a virtual temple for all generations of God's people. This is not the kind of book you

read once and put down. It is designed for a lifetime of slow rereading and reflection.

How to Read the 15 Prophetic Books in the Bible

Not Fortune Tellers

Ezekiel, Obadiah, Habakkuk: what do these names have in common? They are three of the fifteen prophets who have their own books in the Bible. If you have tried to read these books, odds are you got lost in their dense poetry and strange imagery. But these books are vitally important for understanding the overall biblical story.

So let us talk about how to read the prophets. When many people hear the word prophet, they think of a fortune teller, someone who predicts the future. That is what being a prophet means in many cultures, but not in the Bible.

While the biblical prophets sometimes speak about the future, they are far more than fortune tellers. They were Israelites who had a radical encounter with God's presence, and were then commissioned to go and speak on God's behalf, as his representatives.

And what they cared about most was the mutual partnership that existed between God and the Israelites.

The Covenant

God rescued Israel from slavery in Egypt and invited them to become a nation of justice and generosity that would represent his character to the nations. This partnership required all Israelites to give their trust and allegiance to their God alone. In the Bible, this partnership is called the covenant.

But the leaders, the priests and the kings, led Israel astray, and they broke the covenant. This is where the prophets came in, to remind Israel of their role in the partnership. They did this in three ways.

Accusation and Repentance

First, they constantly accused Israel of violating the terms of the covenant. The charges usually included idolatry, alliances with other nations and their gods, and allowing injustice towards the poor. They were like covenant lawyers.

Second, the prophets called the Israelites to repent, which simply means to turn around. They spoke of God's mercy to forgive them if they would just confess and change their ways.

But Israel and its leaders did not change. Things went from bad to worse. And that brings us to the third way the prophets emphasised the covenant.

The Day of the Lord

They announced the consequences of breaking it, which they called the day of the Lord. You may think of the apocalypse, visions of the end of the world. Well, in a sense.

The prophets were mostly interested in how God would bring his justice on Israel's corruption and on the violent nations around them. And while explaining these local events, they often used cosmic imagery. Take Jeremiah.

He described the exile of the Israelites to Babylon as the undoing of creation itself. The land dissolves into chaos and disorder: no light, no animals, no people. Isaiah described the downfall of Babylon as the disintegration of the cosmos: stars falling from the sky, the sun going dark.

For the prophets, whenever God acts in human history to bring justice, it is a day of the Lord. So are the prophets not talking about the end of the world? Hold on.

They are doing many things at once. The cosmic imagery shows how the important events of their day fit into the bigger story of God's mission to bring down every corrupt and violent nation once and for all. The prophets cared about the present and the future.

And the cosmic imagery allowed them to talk about both at the same time. So no matter when you live, the day of the Lord is bad news if you are part of Babylon.

But it is good news if you are waiting for God's kingdom. The day of the Lord pointed to the return of the exiles to Jerusalem, and once again the prophets used cosmic poetry to describe it.

They saw a new Jerusalem like a new Garden of Eden, with all humanity living at peace with each other and with the animals. And there is a new messianic king who restores God's kingdom in a renewed creation.

Those are the three themes in the prophets.

Voices on the Margins

You might think these prophets must have been powerful, persuasive speakers. Some were.

But others lived on the margins. They would often perform strange symbolic acts in public to communicate their message. Ezekiel lay in the dirt and built a model of Jerusalem being attacked by Babylon.

Isaiah walked around naked for three years as a symbol of the humiliation of exile. So did people pay attention to them? Not really. The stories in these books show that the prophets were a minority group, mostly shunned by Israel's leaders.

Their writings were a kind of resistance literature, and most people ignored them, until their warnings came true in the Babylonian exile.

After that, people began to take their words seriously. The works of these earlier prophets were inherited by later, unnamed prophets who studied these texts intensely.

They are the ones who arranged the Hebrew Scriptures as we know them, including the books of the prophets.

The Fifteen Books

There are 15 books of the prophets. The big three are Isaiah, Jeremiah and Ezekiel. Then there is a collection of 12 smaller prophetic works, unified on a single scroll. In each of these books, you will read stories about the prophets, and their poems and visions, all arranged to show the cosmic meaning of Israel's history.

They show how God would turn Israel's tragic story of failure and exile into a story of hope and restoration for all nations. It is that twin message, of prophetic warning and of hope, that the prophets cared about so much. And it is a message we still need to hear today.

Biblical Law

Over 600 Laws

If you start reading the Bible from the beginning, you will get about halfway through the second book, Exodus, and you will come to a collection of ancient laws. Thou shalt do this. Thou shalt not do that.

These laws are all written in the literary style we call prose discourse. They are found all over the second, third, fourth and fifth books of the Bible. There are over 600 laws.

Since reading ancient law codes is not something you and your friends do very often, odds are you will struggle. So let us talk about how to read the law in the Bible. The first thing to remember is that the Bible is not a behaviour manual with a complete list of what to do and not to do to make God happy.

The First Divine Command

The Bible is an epic narrative. But in the story, God does tell people what to do.

The story begins with God's plan to rule the world through humans who will trust him and live by his wisdom. And here we find the first divine command in the Bible.

Do not eat from the tree of knowing good and evil, because the day you do, you will die. But the humans take the authority to know and define good and evil for themselves. And it is not good.

It leads to a world of violence and death, and they are exiled from the garden.

So was this the first law in the Bible? It is the first divine command. It invites people to trust God and live by his wisdom. And while it is not part of the laws given to Israel, it does foreshadow them, because those laws too are invitations to trust God's wisdom.

The Terms of the Covenant

So when do the laws of Israel come? Here is the story. Israel is enslaved in Egypt.

God saves them and then invites them into a covenant relationship, like a marriage. The laws make up the terms of that covenant. Do we get a catalogue of all the laws God gave Israel? No.

We do not get all of the laws, only examples. And these have been strategically placed between stories about how Israel keeps violating the laws. You are supposed to see that Israel is no different from the humans in the garden.

They do not trust God or live by his wisdom. And so it leads to another round of tragedy, violence and death.

And it ends in exile. So while the laws are good and show God's wisdom, they also expose Israel's inability to be God's faithful partners.

Laws of Holiness and Sacrifice

But when you read the laws, you find a lot of strange things, like not allowing clothing to be made of two different fabrics. How does that show God's wisdom?

It is important to realise that many of these laws are ancient ritual symbols that set Israel apart, that is, made them holy. Some laws made Israel distinct from the neighbouring nations, while other laws kept them away from things that, in their culture, symbolised death, disease and moral corruption.

What about all the ritual killing of animals? Sacrifices were also ritual symbols that connected people to God. Since you, a mortal, cannot ascend to God's presence in the heavenly temple, a blameless animal that was offered could go up in your place, covering for your failures so that you could know you are accepted by God.

Laws of Justice

Not all of the laws are ancient rituals. Some of them are about being a good person and treating others well.

But these laws are not just about being good. They are about justice, which is a big deal to God. On the first page of the Bible, we

learn that every human is made in God's image and is worthy of dignity.

These laws apply that ideal in Israel's day. In fact, they still underlie many of the concepts of justice and equality we take for granted today. But some of the laws do not seem just, like laws that allow for slavery.

If you look at those laws in their ancient cultural context, you will see that God is working with Israel as he finds them, pushing them towards justice. Slavery is not abolished, but it is undermined. For example, Israel was supposed to re-enact the Exodus liberation by releasing slaves and forgiving all debts every seven years.

This was revolutionary in the ancient world.

Laws of Sacred Time

Now, what about all the laws about Sabbath rest on the seventh day, and all the seven-day feasts? What is going on with all these settings?

These laws about sacred time are all connected to the first creation narrative in Genesis. God brings order out of chaos in six days, each of which has a clear beginning and end. But when you get to the seventh day, it has no end.

That is because it points to the ideal of humans partnering with God in his rule and his rest. All of these seven-day feasts are rituals that symbolise humanity's true purpose and future.

So all of the laws given to Israel fit into these basic categories. Each category expresses a core ideal of God's wisdom.

Jesus Fulfils the Law

The laws show how those ideals were to be applied in the culture of ancient Israel. But as the story makes clear, Israel failed to fulfil the law over and over. How is God going to get humans to trust his wisdom? Moses, and the prophets after him, trusted that one day God would transform the human heart,

so that people could be faithful covenant partners who trust his wisdom. And that brings us to the story of Jesus.

Jesus said he came to fulfil the law. He was the faithful covenant partner that Israel and all humanity was made to be, but failed to be.

Jesus lived by the divine ideals underlying the laws. He taught that the laws are all fulfilled when you love God and love your neighbour as yourself. And Jesus promised that God's Spirit would come and transform his followers, so that they too could live this way.

So when followers of Jesus read these laws today, we need to remember that they were given to Israel in their ancient cultural setting. You could not follow many of them even if you tried. But what you can do is see God's wisdom in the laws,

and trust that God's Spirit can guide you to follow that wisdom as you learn to love God and to love your neighbour as yourself.

The Books of Solomon

Back to the Garden

In the story of the Bible, King Solomon was the wisest ruler Israel ever had. And there are three books in the Hebrew Scriptures connected to him: Proverbs, Ecclesiastes and the Song of Songs.

They pass down the legacy of Solomon's wisdom, but in a surprising way. So let us talk about how to read the books of Solomon. To really appreciate the story of Solomon's wisdom, we have to go back to the Garden of Eden,

where God created humanity, male and female: Adam and Eve. God commissions them to rule the world together in intimacy and love.

They are kings and queens of creation. Now, in order to rule, you need to be wise. And the humans have a choice about how to gain wisdom.

They could live by God's wisdom, which leads to life, or they could become wise in their own eyes. And that is what they choose: to take the knowledge of good and bad into their own hands.

Immediately, the intimacy between man and woman is broken. They hide their bodies from each other, and then from God. Their choice leads to division and death.

Solomon's Rise and Fall

But the story holds out hope for a future human who will make the right choice and rely on God's wisdom, like King Solomon. He prayed that God would give him the knowledge to know good from bad, so that he could rule with true wisdom.

He reverses the failure of Adam and Eve, and it leads to abundance. In Solomon's day, every Israelite sat in peace under their own fruit tree.

It is as if he is recreating Eden. For a while. But then Solomon fails.

He marries hundreds of women from other nations, and he is deceived into following their gods. This begins Israel's long descent into self-destruction. So when we turn to the books of Solomon, we are invited to learn wisdom from both his successes and his failures.

Proverbs

Let us start with Proverbs. The book of Proverbs is best known for its hundreds of short, memorable sayings that teach us how to live by God's wisdom.

Like this one: trust in the Lord with all your heart, and do not be wise in your own eyes. In Proverbs, living by God's wisdom instead

of your own is called the fear of the Lord. As the book's opening paragraph puts it, the fear of the Lord is the beginning of wisdom.

But Proverbs is not just memorable sayings. It begins with a lot of poetry: nine chapters of speeches from Solomon to his royal sons.

He tells them to pursue God's wisdom, which is symbolised as an elegant woman. Why is wisdom a woman? Remember, in the Garden of Eden, the intimacy of the man and the woman was violated by their failed search for wisdom.

But now in Proverbs, humans who reunite with God's wisdom become what Adam and Eve failed to be: wise human rulers. Proverbs 3 even says that when we embrace Lady Wisdom, we are taking hold of the tree of life. Now we are the ones in the garden.

Proverbs is saying that every day, we all stand before the tree with our own choice to make. And Solomon urges us: choose wisdom and life.

Ecclesiastes

So how does Ecclesiastes fit into Solomon's story? In this book, it is as if we are meeting Solomon near the end of his life, and he offers some sober reflections. Life is hevel.

That is the Hebrew word for vapour or smoke, which is unpredictable and uncontrollable. He constantly talks about life “under the sun”, that is, life outside the garden, and how confusing and difficult it is. Even when you live by God's wisdom, life can be full of disappointments,

leading up to the ultimate disappointment: your own death. That sounds depressing. But at the end of the book, he says we should strive to live by wisdom and the fear of the Lord, just with more realistic expectations.

The Song of Songs

The next book is the Song of Songs, a love poem between a man and a woman.

And it will make you blush. On its basic level of meaning, this book is racy Hebrew love poetry. But remember, in Proverbs, humanity's pursuit of wisdom was portrayed with the symbolism of a man pursuing a woman in a garden.

In this song, it is the woman who is searching and longing for her lover. It is a poetic image of Lady Wisdom pursuing us, so that we can have life. In fact, the song ends with a poem about how this lady's love is more powerful than death itself.

So the song works on two levels. It celebrates the human desire for intimacy, and it says that this desire points to humanity's ultimate purpose: to be united with God and his wisdom,

so that we can rule united with each other. This is why the song ends with the man and the woman united in love under a fruit tree.

So the story of Solomon and these three books invite us to see ourselves within the whole biblical story. They are about how God designed all of us to rule the world by his wisdom, so that we can all find true life.

Why Jesus Told Parables (and How You Can Understand Them)

Stories That Provoke

Jesus of Nazareth was a master teacher, and some of his best-known teachings are told in short stories called parables. The kingdom of heaven is like a merchant looking for pearls, and when he found the ultimate pearl, he sold everything so that he could buy it. That must have been some pearl.

Or the kingdom of God is like a tiny mustard seed that a farmer planted in his garden. It grew and became a huge tree, and birds came to perch in its branches. That is a beautiful image, but what does it mean?

Jesus did not tell parables to make everything clear. He wanted to provoke the imagination and invite people to see what God is doing in the world from a new perspective. So let us talk about how to read the parables of Jesus.



Parables About His Mission

Many great teachers throughout history have used stories to teach their students about morality, religion and philosophy. But Jesus did not use his parables to teach abstract religious or moral ideals. He said that his parables were about himself and his mission.

His mission was to announce that the kingdom of God was arriving on earth as it is in heaven. In Jesus' day, the Israelites were ruled by the Roman Empire, but their Scriptures promised that one day their God would come to rule his people as king.

So many Israelites wanted to revolt against Rome and fight for their freedom. This is what some people thought of as the kingdom of God.

But Jesus was a poor, travelling prophet, healing the sick and inviting people to follow him. He said that this was the arrival of God's kingdom. That did not fit people's expectations.

The Upside-Down Kingdom

So Jesus used some parables to help people imagine that his small movement was the arrival of God's kingdom. Like the parable that the kingdom of God is yeast hidden in a lump of dough.

You might not see its influence, but it is going to change everything. Jesus also told parables about the upside-down values of God's kingdom: how the least important people in the world are actually the most important people to God, especially those who are poor and of low status. Take the parable of the business owner who

hired workers throughout the day, in the morning, later in the day, and even towards the end of the day.

When it was time to pay everyone, he paid them all the same wage. Jesus is showing that money and status are irrelevant to God, who offers his generous mercy to everybody.

Parables of Warning

Not all of the parables have happy endings. Some are very intense. Jesus stood in the tradition of Israel's prophets, who also told parables to criticise Israel's leaders because they mistook their own kingdom for God's. Jesus warned the leaders of his day that if they did not accept his offer of God's kingdom, they were headed for destruction.

Take the parable of the landowner who built a wonderful vineyard and expected it to produce fruit. Jesus takes this parable from the prophet Isaiah, but he adapts it. The landowner appoints managers to take care of the vineyard.

At harvest, he sends servants to collect the fruit, but the managers kill the servants. So the landowner sends his own son to confront the managers, and they kill him too.

Then Jesus asked the people around him, what do you think this landowner should do? He is going to punish those managers and hire new ones. Jesus knew that if Israel kept on its current path, it would be destroyed by Rome. So in parables like this, he is forcing people to make a decision about his offer of God's kingdom.

Why Speak in Parables?

Are people going to reject him, ignore him, or trust and follow him? Now, if this message of God's kingdom is so important, why cloak it in parables? Why not be clearer? Through riddles and parables, Jesus could make very bold claims that revealed truth to people who were open-minded. Those who had ears to hear could ponder them and go deeper. But the parables would also conceal his message from those who were against him, so that he could buy more time.

Buy time for what? Jesus was preparing his closest followers for the greatest surprise of all. He claimed that Israel's God was coming to rule over his people, not through coercion or violent force, but through self-giving love, as he was going to die for their sins. But his death was not the end.

He said that his death would be like a tiny seed buried in the ground. But then it would grow and produce a crop with many seeds.

A Storehouse of Treasure

So these parables explain who Jesus was and what he was doing. The Gospel authors have preserved them so that every generation of Jesus' followers can read and ponder them, and imagine how God's kingdom is still at work even today.

These ancient parables are still full of new surprises and challenges. They are like a storehouse packed with treasures, some new and some old.

And it is all waiting to be discovered.

New Testament Letters: Historical Context

Reading Someone Else's Mail

Near the end of the Bible are 21 letters written to communities of Jesus' followers throughout the ancient Roman Empire. When you read them, you are in a sense reading someone else's mail. The letters were written by the apostles, the people Jesus appointed to spread the good news about his kingdom, and they wrote to Jesus' followers living in different cities around the Roman world.

These letters were all written in a style called prose discourse. Now, when you read a letter that was not written to you, there is likely a great deal of background information that is assumed but not mentioned.

The letters in the Bible are no different. So let us talk about how to read the New Testament letters in their historical context. There are three levels of historical context to keep in mind.

Context One: The Story of Scripture

The first is how all the letters fit into the larger storyline of the Scriptures. The story begins with God creating humanity as his partners to rule creation with him. But we choose to rule on our own terms, and that leads to violence, exile and death.

But God promises a man named Abraham that life and blessing will spread to all nations through him and his descendants, renewing God's vision for humanity. And Jesus said he came to bring that promise to its fulfilment through his life, death and resurrection. So the apostles saw themselves as heralds announcing the arrival of God's kingdom in Jesus.

When the apostle Paul wrote to the house churches in Rome about the good news, he said his job was to summon people of all nations to give their allegiance to Jesus, the exalted King of the world. That is a bold thing to say to people living in the capital city of the Roman Empire, whose allegiance was supposed to be to Caesar. And that brings us to the second important context for understanding the New Testament letters: the culture of the Roman Empire in the first century.

Context Two: The Roman World

Rome ruled all the territories around the Mediterranean Sea. They built their empire by conquering and enslaving their enemies and then imposing heavy taxes. The emperor and his small circle controlled all the power and wealth, and they knew how to deal with people who threatened the social order.

Most people lived without much money or stability. And Roman culture had a very clear hierarchy. Men from important families, with money and education, could move ahead in society.

But women, slaves, children and the poor were always at a disadvantage and treated as inferior. Yet in a community of people who followed Jesus, everyone was treated with love and equal dignity. In Roman life, it was unheard of for people of high status to associate with those below them.

But the apostles said that through Jesus, God had given the gift of his love to everyone, without regard to their status. So in that context, these letters were counter-cultural, and they broke down the barriers between people.

Context Three: The Situation of Each Letter

That brings us to the last level of context: the situational context of each letter, meaning the specific issues in the church of a particular city that prompted the letter in the first place. Take Paul's letter to the Christians in Rome. It is tempting to read this letter, focus on all the important theology, and overlook why he wrote it.

So why did he write it? Towards the end, he talks about how Jewish food laws and sacred days had become controversial between Jewish and non-Jewish followers of Jesus, and this was creating divisions in the church. If you read carefully, you can see that some Christians of higher social status were treating Jewish followers of Jesus with contempt.

And the Jewish Christians were returning the favour, condemning the non-Jews as second-rate followers of Jesus. So all the ideas and theology in the first part of the letter were crafted to address those very problems.

Paul acknowledges that the Roman Christians have big differences in culture, theology and social status. But he wants them to realise that they are unified by their faith in Jesus, who is the real centre of their church.

What This Means for Us

But if the letter was written to someone else, what should you get out of it? You do not live in ancient Rome. In these letters, we see the apostles challenging and transforming every part of their first-century culture and life with the good news about King Jesus. And by watching them, we gain wisdom about how that same good news can transform our culture as well.

There is one more helpful step in reading the New Testament letters: learning to follow the flow of thought from the letter's beginning all the way to its end. That is what we will look at next.

New Testament Letters: Literary Context

One Whole Literary Work

Near the end of the Bible are 21 letters from leaders of the early Jesus movement. They were written to small church communities in cities throughout the Roman world. Now, writing letters took a lot of money and effort in the ancient world.

So each one was crafted carefully from beginning to end, and that means we should read each one as a whole literary work. So let us talk about how to read the New Testament letters in their literary context.

How Paul's Letters Were Made

Of all the early Christian leaders, the apostle Paul wrote the most letters. We have 13 of them in the New Testament. Many of us imagine him alone in his study, writing long theological essays.

But Paul did not work or write alone. In fact, he often names people from his team who helped him produce the letters, like Timothy or Silas.

Paul was constantly with his missionary teammates on the road, working out ideas as they talked and debated together. And Paul would have collected speeches, poems and prayers in notebooks, like the ones he mentions in his second letter to Timothy.

So Paul would get the right teammates in a room and start pulling together old and new material. Then they would hire a professional scribe and work through drafts until they were satisfied with how it worked together as one whole. Then they would send it off.

The letter would be given to a trusted teammate, who would also be given instructions on how to perform it before the recipients, that is, read it aloud. Most people back then did not read. Paul mentions more than once in his letters that they were designed to be heard, which is why they often sound like written speeches.

So it is important for us to read and listen to these letters from beginning to end too, so we can appreciate how each part contributes to the whole.

The Shape of a Letter

Every culture has its own practice for how to organise a letter, and in the first century there was a standard format. There is the opening, which names the author and then the receiver. Then comes a prayer of thanks or a greeting.

Then comes the body of the letter. This is the main reason for writing in the first place: what the receiver is supposed to know or do something about.

Then comes the conclusion, which could include greetings, travel plans, a final request or a prayer. So it is helpful to see how a New Testament letter breaks down into these parts. Let us take Paul's letter to the Ephesians as an example.

Ephesians: The Main Idea

There is the opening, and then a long prayer of thanksgiving to God. In the centre of this opening prayer, Paul introduces the main idea of the whole letter. It is about God's plan

to unite together all things in heaven and earth in Messiah Jesus. What does that mean? As we move into the body of the letter, Paul repeats and unpacks this rich idea. But in the body of the letter, it is easy to get lost and lose track of what Paul is even talking about.

The letter to the Ephesians has about 3,000 words, and that one is short compared to his other letters. But remember, Paul wrote these letters to be heard aloud.

So he usually gives clues to the progression of thought with transition words like “therefore”, “because of this” or “so then”. The body of Ephesians breaks down into many paragraphs, and they all begin with these transition words.

Ephesians: Following the Flow

Each paragraph has its own main idea. The first is about how the risen Jesus is King of everything and everyone. And as for you, that

is, non-Israelites, you are now included in the new humanity God is creating.

Therefore, God's one new family consists of people from all nations. God has unified a new humanity in Jesus. That is the core idea here.

That theme unites all the paragraphs in chapters 1 to 3. Then we come to chapter 4, and we get a very significant transition: therefore. That transition word is a hinge between the first and second halves of the letter.

God has unified a new humanity in Jesus. Therefore, what? Let us keep going and summarise the paragraphs of chapter 4. God's one new humanity is very diverse.

So we must live together as God's new creation. And that, therefore, requires that we learn to love and forgive each other, because we are one. This section is all about living in unity.

So you can now see how all the parts of the letter fit together into one flow of thought. God has unified a new humanity in Jesus. Therefore, live in a way that fosters that unity.

A Roadmap for Every Letter

Seeing it broken down like this is like having a roadmap, so you do not get lost. And you can read every New Testament letter this way.

Break it down into smaller parts to see the message of each paragraph. Then trace repeated ideas and transition words to see how they all connect back together. Then you will see how the apostles brilliantly combined all the pieces into a literary whole that spoke to Jesus' first followers and can still speak to us today.

How to Read the Bible: Apocalyptic Literature

What Apocalypse Really Means

It is the end of the world. The moon turns to blood, mountains crumble, mutant locusts swarm. These are just some of the strange images we find in parts of the Bible called apocalyptic.

Most people think the biblical word apocalypse means the end of the world, but it actually does not mean that at all. So let us talk about how to read apocalyptic literature in the Bible. Apocalypse is a Greek word that means to uncover or reveal.

An apocalypse is when you suddenly see the true nature of something you could not see before, because none of us always sees things the way they really are.

We all develop familiar ways of seeing the world that can limit or blur our vision. So an apocalypse is a revelation.

God Pulls Back the Curtain

In the Bible, an apocalypse is when God pulls back the curtain to show someone what is really going on in the world from a divine

perspective. Take Isaiah the prophet. He is suddenly transported in a vision into God's throne room.

He is in God's temple, described as a bridge between heaven and earth. And there, God gives him a divine perspective on Israel's past, present and future,

so that Isaiah can bring challenge and comfort to God's people in his own day. Or think about the apostle Paul, who was trying to stop the movement of Jesus, but was stopped in his tracks by a vision of the risen Jesus himself. He realised that he was fighting against the very thing he had been hoping for, and it changed the course of his life.

So these apocalypses give people a heavenly perspective on their earthly situation. They can give hope, they can challenge you, or they can make you change everything. Now, those are biblical stories about people having an apocalypse.

Apocalyptic Literature

There are also whole sections of biblical books where a prophet describes extended apocalyptic dreams and visions. We call this apocalyptic literature. And reading these dreams and visions is difficult.

They are filled with strange images. Take Daniel. He sees ferocious beasts coming up out of a dark sea, trampling people on the land.

And then a figure called the Son of Man is exalted to rule the world. What is going on? Apocalyptic literature is written in a poetic,

imaginative style, and it is packed with symbolism. How can you know what these symbols mean? First, by studying the rest of your Bible.

Reading the Symbols

Apocalyptic imagery is based on biblical design patterns that begin in the book of Genesis and develop throughout the Bible. Take the chaotic sea in the first sentences of the Bible, which God tames but does not eliminate as he orders creation. The sea becomes an image of danger, death and cosmic chaos.

The dry land, which comes up out of the sea, is the safe, ordered place where humans are supposed to rule as God's image. On the land are also beasts that humans are supposed to oversee. But keep reading, and the humans are deceived by a beast and start acting like violent beasts themselves.

Sometimes a prophet will tell you what a symbol means. In Daniel, we are told that those beasts symbolise violent human kingdoms.

But more often, the authors simply assume you know how to trace an image through the biblical story to understand its meaning.

The Revelation

Now let us look at the last book of the Bible, the Revelation, because it is one long vision. The whole thing is an apocalypse.

And it works the same way. It begins with John the visionary transported to God's throne room, where he sees the risen Jesus as

the exalted King of the world. But Jesus is depicted as a bloody lamb.

It is a design pattern showing that Jesus is the sacrificial lamb of Israel's Passover and of the Day of Atonement. He gave his life for the sins of the world. Then John sees the ultimate beastly dragon, the spiritual power that energises violent earthly empires.

It is cast out by Jesus, the world's true King. Now, when you read the Revelation, you may be struck by all the cosmic destruction and violence.

It happens over and over again. In the Revelation, there are three seven-part cycles of God's judgment. This is another design pattern, one that connects the stories of the flood, the ten plagues on Egypt, the exile to Babylon, and more.

These are moments when humans unleash so much violence and death into the world that God hands them over to self-destruction. It is like a reversal of creation in Genesis 1, as God allows the world and humans to sink back into darkness and disorder. That is sobering.

The Beginning, Not the End

It is. But remember, in Genesis 1, God overcame darkness and chaos with his light and life. And so too in the Revelation.

The death of Jesus, and the death of the world as we know it, is the pathway into the renewed creation that began with the resurrection of Jesus. So while the Revelation feels like the end of

the world, it is actually about the beginning of the renewed world, where heaven and earth are reunited, and God's human images rule all creation in the love and power of God. This is a lot to take in.

There is a great deal in these books that is still hard to understand, but the purpose of apocalyptic literature is very clear: to give us a heavenly perspective on our earthly circumstances, so that every generation of God's people can be challenged, comforted and given hope for the future.

A Whole New World Waiting

In this series on how to read the Bible, we have looked at all the styles of writing in the Bible: narrative, poetry and discourse.

And we have learned how to read all the main sections of the Bible. This is sophisticated and beautiful literature, and you can see why the Bible is one of the most influential books in human history.

Every part fits into the unified story that leads to Jesus. And it invites us into a lifetime of reading and meditation. There is a whole new world waiting to be discovered in your Bible.

The Historical Reliability of the Bible

Moses Speaking German

When Martin Luther translated the Bible into German, he is reported to have said: “I want to make Moses so German that no one would suspect he was a Jew.” That can sound controversial. But understand what he was after. He wanted the Scriptures to speak the language of ordinary people. And that Bible went on to shape a civilisation.

The Western world rests on a foundation of Judeo-Christian ethics. The conviction that every human being has intrinsic worth did not come from nowhere. It comes from the Bible.

The Question Before Us

So here is the question I want us to face honestly: should the Bible's history cause us to doubt its reliability and its authority?

Some of you have heard it said that all we have is a translation of a translation of a translation. Can we actually get to the bottom of a question like this: is what we hold today what the original authors

wrote? I say we can. And what about the Dead Sea Scrolls? We will come to them.

What I Am Arguing

Let me be plain. I am arguing that the Bible is historically reliable and that it communicates truth. That does not mean its heroes are polished. The greatest individuals spoken about in its pages are broken and flawed.

And here is my own testimony: through the teachings of Jesus of Nazareth, I have seen him accomplish what I could not.

Jesus died, and his story did not stop there. We are still talking about him 2,000 years later, in a way we do not talk about the other messianic figures of his era. When they died, their movements died with them. His did not. The Bible became the most influential book in Western civilisation, shaping what we now call the modern world. So let us talk about the historical reliability of what we call the Bible.

Not One Book, But a Library

The Bible is not one book so much as 66 books, written over about 1,600 years, on three continents, by about 40 authors, in three languages.

There is complexity in that, and there is a caveat. If you hold a Roman Catholic Bible, you have 73 books. An Eastern Orthodox Bible has between 76 and 81, depending on the church. The fullest

canon in Christian history belongs to the Ethiopian church, which counts 81 books in its narrower canon and 88 in its broader one. So even the question of which books we are discussing has a history of its own.

Despite the dates, cultures, peoples, languages and data we will work through, I say the Bible's history should not cause us to doubt its authority. It should cause us to appreciate that authority, and inspire us to read and study it more.

A Challenge Worth Answering

Not everyone agrees. Kristin Swenson, associate professor of religion at Virginia Commonwealth University, puts it this way: “Considering that we don't have one original and undisputed Bible, but rather a collection that evolved over a long period of time, for which the evidence is copies of copies, not all of which agree with one another, how can I, as a person, believe in it, much less live by it?”

I grant her this much: we must look at the data, and in every field, people look at the same data and reach different conclusions. But what I am presenting is the opposite of her conclusion. When we look at the data, we can have confidence to believe the Bible, and to live by it.

Two Words: Canon and Apocryphal

Let me define two words, so you know exactly what I mean by them.

Canon comes from the Greek kanōn, a rule or a list. In the ancient world it was a measuring rod. Over time the word came to mean the standard by which everything else is measured. You already understand this: Star Wars has its canon, and so does Lord of the Rings. For our purposes, a canon is an exclusive list of authoritative books: the books a community recognised as uniquely, divinely inspired Scripture.

Apocryphal, from the Greek apokryphon, means obscure, doubtful or secret. It refers to what lies outside the canon, and it does not automatically mean heretical. Some apocryphal literature is truly wild, like the Gnostic writings we will touch on later. Some of it teaches nothing wrong at all; it was simply never recognised as carrying the authority of Scripture.

The word was used in various ways. One text found at Nag Hammadi in Egypt in 1945 calls itself an apocryphon: the Secret Book of John. In the same collection, it is followed by the Gospel of Thomas, which we will return to.

How We Will Trace the Evidence

I want to take you through three periods that matter for how the Old Testament came together: the period before Christianity, the first 400 years of the church, and then, about a thousand years later, the Middle Ages and the Reformation.

In each period we look at four kinds of evidence. Canon lists: the lists that named which books bore divine authority, even while

those books circulated as separate scrolls. Ancient statements: how people actually treated this literature. Manuscripts: the physical documents that carry the text. And citations: how these books were quoted.

We begin before Christianity, with the Jewish Scriptures in the time of Jesus.

Josephus and 4 Ezra

How did the Jews of that era understand Scripture? One of our most important witnesses is the historian Josephus, writing at the end of the first century: “For we have not an innumerable multitude of books among us, disagreeing from and contradicting one another, as the Greeks have, but only twenty-two books.”

Another Jewish writing from the same period, 4 Ezra, says: “Make public the twenty-four books that you wrote first, and let the worthy and the unworthy read them; but keep the seventy that were written last, in order to give them to the wise among your people.” It draws a line between 24 books for everyone, the canon, and 70 other writings reserved for the wise.

22, 24 or 39: The Same Books

My Protestant Bible has 39 books in its Old Testament. So why do the Jewish sources say 22 or 24? Because they are the same books, counted differently.

The count of 22 treats double books such as 1 and 2 Samuel as one, puts the twelve minor prophets together as one book, and combines Ezra with Nehemiah, Judges with Ruth, and Jeremiah with Lamentations. The count of 24 does the same, except that it separates Ruth from Judges and Lamentations from Jeremiah.

Why 22? Partly because some ancient Jewish writers matched the number of books to the 22 letters of the Hebrew alphabet, and later Christian writers defended the number for exactly that reason. There were practical reasons too: the twelve minor prophets fit comfortably on one scroll.

The Dead Sea Scrolls: A Library, Not a Book

The Dead Sea Scrolls date from roughly the third century BC to the first century AD. Let me correct a common mistake. They are not a single book. They are a library, found in caves near the north-western shore of the Dead Sea, and they came from different groups. We in the modern world put them together because they were found in the same place. So when someone says “it's in the Dead Sea Scrolls, therefore…”, be careful. That is a leap.

Many of the scrolls are linked to the community at Qumran, a sectarian group most scholars identify as the Essenes, whom Josephus describes. They had withdrawn from Jerusalem and its temple worship, which they regarded as corrupt, and rejected its priests and scribes. In the desert they built a small, devout, very strict community, and they produced a great deal of literature, including many copies of Old Testament books.

Moses and the Prophets

One of their documents, the Community Rule (1QS), speaks of doing what God "commanded by the hand of Moses and by the hand of all his servants the prophets." That was their standard: what came through Moses and through the prophets. They give us no list, but references like this give us a frame.

The prologue to Sirach, from the second century BC, says: "My grandfather Jesus, who had devoted himself especially to the reading of the Law and the Prophets and the other books of our ancestors…" Stop there. This is not the Jesus you are thinking of. Yeshua, or Joshua, was one of the most common names in the ancient world. And notice what he read: the Law, the Prophets and the other books. That is the same three-part shape as the Tanakh.

Jews do not call their Bible the Old Testament. That is a Christian term. The earliest Christian list of "the books of the Old Covenant" comes from Melito of Sardis in the second century.

What's Missing, and Why It Doesn't Shake Me

The Dead Sea Scrolls contain every book of our Old Testament except Esther, and possibly Nehemiah. They also contain many copies of other books: Jubilees, the Enoch literature, the Community Rule and more.

What do we make of Esther's absence? First, we look at how books are quoted. When I say quotation, I mean something specific: a passage introduced by "as it is written", "as Scripture says" or "as

the Spirit of God spoke." By that standard, Genesis is never formally quoted in the scrolls. Does that mean Qumran rejected Genesis? No. No one in ancient Judaism disputed Genesis, and copies of it are among the most numerous in the scrolls.

So is Esther not canon because it is missing? No. That is an argument from silence, and absence of evidence is not evidence of absence. Marco Polo travelled from Italy into Asia and never once mentioned the Great Wall of China. Did the wall not exist? Of course it did. Just because we think someone should have mentioned something does not mean they had to.

These documents are about 2,000 years old. Esther may simply not have survived. There may also have been other reasons. Esther was somewhat controversial in ancient Judaism, because it is the only book of the Hebrew Bible that never uses the divine name, Yahweh. God is present throughout it, but never named.

Philo and the New Testament Witness

Cross over to Egypt. Philo of Alexandria, a highly influential Jewish writer, quotes the Torah thousands of times. He does not quote every book of the Jewish canon, but he never once quotes the books later called the Apocrypha or Deuterocanon, the ones found in the Roman Catholic Bible.

Then there is the New Testament: 27 books written by the earliest Christians, who were Jews who believed Jesus was their Messiah. They quote the most important Old Testament books most often.

But they do not formally quote every book. The Song of Songs is never quoted in the New Testament, and neither is Joshua by the strict “it is written” standard, though Joshua is mentioned.

The New Testament never quotes the Apocrypha as Scripture, but it does allude to it. Hebrews 11 alludes to the martyrs of 2 Maccabees 6 and 7, and Jude quotes 1 Enoch 1:9. So the quotation evidence shows a range: some books quoted, some not.

Why This Matters to You

The question was never whether the Bible has a history. It does. The question is whether that history undermines it, and the evidence says no. By the end of the first century, Jewish writers were counting their Scriptures, and those are the books in your Old Testament today.

John Lennox, emeritus professor of mathematics at Oxford, has spent years making one point to sceptics: biblical faith is not a leap in the dark. It is a commitment based on evidence. That is exactly what we have been doing in this session. We have not asked you to switch off your mind. We have asked you to look at the data.

The Council of Nicaea: What It Was

In AD 325, about 300 bishops gathered at Nicaea, in what is now Turkey, at the invitation of Emperor Constantine. It was the first time leaders from across the Christian world had met in one council.

Let me say this as clearly as I can, because you will hear the opposite from novels, documentaries and social media: the Council of Nicaea did not decide which books belong in the Bible. The canon was not on its agenda. Not one of its decisions concerns the books of Scripture. Anyone who tells you Constantine chose the Bible at Nicaea is repeating a myth, not history.

Why Nicaea Was Necessary

Nicaea dealt with the most important question in the Christian faith: who is Jesus?

A priest in Alexandria named Arius was teaching that the Son of God was a created being, the highest of all creatures, but not eternal God. His followers had a slogan: “There was when he was not.” The teaching was spreading fast, and it was splitting the church.

This was not a quarrel over words. If Jesus is a creature, then a creature died for you, and a creature cannot reconcile you to God. Everything the Gospel stands on was at stake.

The timing matters too. Only twelve years earlier, in 313, the Edict of Milan had ended the persecution of Christians. According to ancient accounts, some of the bishops who came to Nicaea still bore the scars of torture from those years. These were not politicians inventing a religion. They were men who had suffered for a faith they had already received.

The council answered Arius with the Nicene Creed. It confessed that the Son is “begotten, not made,” and “of one substance with the Father.” In other words, Jesus is fully God. The council did not invent this belief. It defended what the church had confessed from the beginning, the faith of John 1:1: “In the beginning was the Word, and the Word was with God, and the Word was God.”

So when were the New Testament books recognised? Gradually, by use, across the churches. By about AD 180, Irenaeus was defending the four Gospels as the only true Gospels. In AD 367, Athanasius of Alexandria listed exactly the 27 books of our New Testament. Regional councils at Hippo (393) and Carthage (397) confirmed what the churches were already reading. The church did not create the canon. It recognised it.

Why I Trust the Authenticity of the Bible

Let me give you four reasons.

First, the number of manuscripts. We have more than 5,800 Greek manuscripts of the New Testament, in whole or in part, and over 10,000 more in Latin, besides other ancient languages. Compare that with the classics no historian doubts. Homer's Iliad, the best-attested work of the ancient world after the New Testament, survives in fewer than 2,000 manuscripts. The first six books of Tacitus' Annals survive in a single manuscript. If we doubt the New Testament, we must throw out the whole of ancient history first.

Second, how early the manuscripts are. A small fragment of John's Gospel, known as P52, is usually dated to the first half of the second century, though some scholars date it later. That puts it within decades of the original. For most ancient works, the gap between the original and our earliest copy is many centuries.

Third, the Dead Sea Scrolls. Before 1947, our oldest complete Hebrew manuscripts of Isaiah dated from around AD 1000. Then the Great Isaiah Scroll was found at Qumran, dated to around 125 BC, over a thousand years older. When scholars compared the two, the text matched closely; the differences were mostly spelling and small details. A thousand years of copying, and the message had not changed. So when someone tells you it is a translation of a translation of a translation, that is your answer. We do not translate from translations. We translate from Hebrew and Greek manuscripts, and we can check them against copies over a thousand years older.

Fourth, the variants are honest, and they are small. Yes, the manuscripts contain differences. Scholars do not hide them; they print them in the footnotes of your Bible. The vast majority are spelling, word order or slips of the pen. No central teaching of the Christian faith depends on a disputed passage.

C.S. Lewis was a professor of medieval and Renaissance literature at Cambridge, a man who spent his life reading myths and legends. He said of the Gospels: “I have been reading poems, romances, vision-literature, legends, myths all my life. I know what they are

like. I know that not one of them is like this." The Gospels do not read like legend. They read like eyewitness testimony.

Why Enoch and Similar Books Are Not Scripture

Some of you have heard that the Book of Enoch was "removed" from the Bible. It was never in the Hebrew Bible. Let me show you why the church did not receive Enoch, Jubilees, the Gnostic gospels and similar books as Scripture.

The church asked four simple questions. Was it written by a prophet or an apostle, or someone directly connected to one? Does it agree with the faith already received? Was it received widely across the churches, not in one corner? Is it as old as it claims to be?

Enoch fails the test of authorship. It claims to be written by Enoch, who lived before the flood. But scholars date its parts to between roughly the third century BC and the first century AD, thousands of years after Enoch. It was written under his name, not by him. And it was never part of the Jewish Scriptures that Jesus read. Of all the world's churches, only the Ethiopian church received it.

What about Jude quoting Enoch? Quoting a book does not make it Scripture. Paul quotes Greek poets in Acts 17:28 and Titus 1:12, and the Greek writer Menander in 1 Corinthians 15:33. Nobody thinks those poets wrote the Bible. When Jude quotes Enoch, he affirms that one statement is true, not that the whole book is inspired.

The Gnostic gospels fail the tests of age and agreement. Books like the Gospel of Thomas come from the second century or later, long after the apostles. They teach a secret knowledge for a select few, and they contradict the faith the apostles delivered “once for all” (Jude 3).

The Apocrypha, or Deuterocanon, fail the test of prophecy. These books were never in the Hebrew canon. Josephus said that after the time of Artaxerxes, the exact succession of the prophets had ceased. And 1 Maccabees, one of these very books, admits that there was no prophet in Israel in its own day (1 Maccabees 9:27). These books are valuable history, and the church has always read them with profit. But they do not claim prophetic authority, and neither did the Jews who first read them.

So the books in your Bible were not chosen by a committee or an emperor. They were recognised by the people of God because they carried the marks of God's voice from the start.

C.S. Lewis put it this way: “I believe in Christianity as I believe that the sun has risen: not only because I see it, but because by it I see everything else.”

So do not be afraid of the questions. Bring them. The Bible has nothing to hide.

Acknowledgement

Much of the research on the formation of the canon and the textual evidence in this section draws on the work of Wes Huff.

The Unseen Realm: The Supernatural Worldview of the Scriptures

Do You Really Understand What the Bible Is About?

I am going to ask you a question that may offend you a little. Do you really understand what the Bible is about? Not the verses you have memorised. Not the sermons you have heard. The Bible itself, as the men who wrote it understood it.

In this session I am going to open a door that many believers have never walked through: the supernatural worldview of the Bible. I am going to take you through it layer by layer, show you the Scriptures it stands on, and then teach you how to read your own Bible through this lens.

Here is my first conviction, and everything else rests on it: we must take the context of Scripture seriously.

Context Is More Than the Verses Around Your Verse

When most of us hear the word context, we think of the verses just before and just after the one we are reading. That is a context. It is part of context. But it is not the whole of it.

Taking context seriously means trying to read the Scriptures the way the original writer thought. When a biblical writer, moved by the Spirit of God, wrote something down, he had a very particular worldview and a very particular purpose for writing. He had specific questions in his head.

Most of the time, what we bring to the text is not what the writer had in mind, and we certainly do not share his worldview. Instead, we bring our own questions, our own worldview, our denominational preferences and our traditions. Whether we know it or not, these become filters for what we see in Scripture.

Hear me clearly: context does not mean your tradition. Context does not mean your denomination. Context means the world of the man God used to write the text.

Selectively Supernatural

There is a problem in the church I call Christian scepticism. We are believers. We believe in God, in Jesus, in the deity of Christ and the inspiration of Scripture. But we are selectively supernatural.

There may be a hundred supernatural things in Scripture. We keep the ten we consider core, and for the rest we look for an

explanation. We find a way not to read those passages the way the original writer meant them.

The writer did not consider those passages weird at all. An ancient reader would know exactly why that material is in the text and what role it is playing. We are the ones who filter it out.

Most of us do not do this on purpose. We do it reflexively, because we are modern people. We are children of the Enlightenment and of a materialist society. We have a scientific worldview, and the biblical writers did not. Many sincere believers are not opposed to the supernatural; certain passages simply make them uncomfortable, so they treat them as peripheral and drift away from them. Sometimes God has to provoke us out of that attitude. Consider this session your provocation.

What Is the Harm?

You may ask: what is the harm if I never think about any of this? On one level, there is no harm. You will still hear and embrace the gospel. You will still understand who Jesus is and what he did. No one needs a book on the unseen realm to be saved.

But on another level, if you want to understand the book you hold in your lap and call the Word of God, there is a lot of harm in ignoring it.

Let me say something provocative: not every passage in the Bible is directly about Jesus. The purity laws of Leviticus are there for a reason, but they are not a portrait of Jesus. Yet these passages

operate within a worldview, and they form a bigger picture in which Jesus is the linchpin figure. They teach us big concepts such as sacred space, cosmic geography, and the battle between the true God and the other gods.

All of these things matter. They would have been obvious to an ancient reader. They are not obvious to us at all. If you want to understand the fullness of Scripture, you need to see them.

The Bible Is Connected

Some of you have long suspected that the ideas in your Bible must be connected, that this idea over here must relate to that idea over there, but you cannot see how. Your suspicion is correct.

The Bible is an intelligently designed, intelligently planned and intelligently executed work. God knew what he was doing. He chose the right people, prepared them providentially, and they did the job well. But the connections they built in, which their first readers would have caught immediately, are invisible to us.

That is a problem, because then we cannot see the layers of the story. We do not know what is in the foreground and what is in the background. We cannot see how an idea is carried from Genesis to Revelation. We cannot see the threads or the trail of breadcrumbs, because the Bible is usually taught to us like a textbook: here is a passage, here are three points, memorise them, and that is your lesson for today.

Every passage of Scripture connects to more than one thing. That is why I tell people to read the Bible as if it were a novel. It is not fiction, but it is a good exercise. When you read a novel, you know the author is deliberately doing something to you. You notice a detail and think, I am going to see that again. Your senses are alert. That is how the Bible is put together, and that is how we must read it.

Three Rules for Reading

So I give you three rules for reading Scripture this way.

First, do not read the Bible through post-biblical filters. Creeds are precious, but creeds are short. They fit on a page, and they do not comment on most of what is in the Bible. So do not make a creed or a later tradition the lens for every passage.

Second, read each Testament in its own context. Read the Old Testament in the intellectual world of the ancient Near East: the Semitic world, Egypt and Babylon. Read the New Testament in light of the Old Testament, and in light of the Jewish literature written between the Testaments. In those roughly four hundred years, faithful Jewish writers who believed the Old Testament was the Word of God were studying it and trying to connect the dots, just as we do. The New Testament writers knew those efforts, read many of them, and at times used their language, as we see in material from the Dead Sea Scrolls. Of course, the apostles had something those writers never had: they lived after Jesus.

Third, do not dismiss or filter out the supernatural worldview of the biblical writers. Context is king, and the supernatural worldview is part of the context.

The Psalm That Stops Scholars in Their Tracks

Psalm 82 is a passage that can stop a trained scholar in his tracks. Many people have studied the Bible for years, even in the original languages, and never noticed what it says. Read it slowly with me.

> *God has taken his place in the divine council; in the midst of the gods he holds judgment. (Psalm 82:1, ESV)*

The first word, God, is the Hebrew Elohim, and the grammar shows it refers to the one God of Israel. But the second word, gods, is the very same word: Elohim. Here is God, presiding over other elohim in a council, and judging them.

The first reaction of most readers is: this sounds like a pantheon, like Greek mythology. The second is: how have I read my Bible for so long and never seen this?

Read on. In verse 6, God says to these beings: “You are gods, sons of the Most High, all of you; nevertheless, like men you shall die, and fall like any prince” (Psalm 82:6–7, ESV). The Most High is the God of Israel. So these are the sons of God: spiritual beings, members of his council, and God is angry with them. Verses 2 to 5 tell us why: they have judged unjustly and abandoned the weak and the needy.

Not Just Men

Many commentaries say, in effect, there is nothing to see here: the gods in Psalm 82 are just men, Jewish elders or judges.

But look at Psalm 89:

> *Let the heavens praise your wonders, O LORD, your faithfulness in the assembly of the holy ones! For who in the skies can be compared to the LORD? Who among the heavenly beings is like the LORD, a God greatly to be feared in the council of the holy ones, and awesome above all who are around him? (Psalm 89:5–7, ESV)*

The ESV footnote tells you that heavenly beings is literally sons of God. Here is the same council, the same sons of God, and the council is in the skies. Jewish elders do not assemble or rule in the heavens. The council is heavenly.

What Jesus Did with Psalm 82

Now watch what Jesus himself does with Psalm 82. In John 10, Jesus says, “I and the Father are one” (John 10:30), and the crowd picks up stones to kill him. Jesus answers: “Is it not written in your Law, ‘I said, you are gods’?” (John 10:34).

The common explanation says Jesus is calming them down: the gods in Psalm 82 are just people, so we are all sons of God, and you should not be upset with me. But that makes Jesus defend his deity by saying he is just like them. That makes no sense. Four verses

later, he says, “the Father is in me and I am in the Father” (John 10:38). He does not back off one inch.

Here is what Jesus is actually doing. He takes them back to Psalm 82, where Scripture already has a category for sons of God who are more than human, because everywhere else in the Old Testament the sons of God are the heavenly host. He has just placed himself in that category. And who presides over the council in Psalm 82? The Father. Jesus says the Father is in him and he is in the Father. In other words: I am not only more than mortal; I am Lord over the heavenly host. Read this way, Jesus is not retreating. He is defending his deity point-blank.

The Council at Work

Psalm 82 is not alone. In 1 Kings 22, wicked King Ahab wants King Jehoshaphat to join him in battle at Ramoth-gilead. Ahab's prophets all promise victory. Jehoshaphat asks whether there is a prophet of the LORD, and Ahab replies that there is one, Micaiah, but he hates him because he never prophesies anything good about him.

Micaiah says:

> *I saw the LORD sitting on his throne, and all the host of heaven standing beside him on his right hand and on his left; and the LORD said, “Who will entice Ahab, that he may go up and fall at Ramoth-gilead?” (1 Kings 22:19–20, ESV)*

One says one thing and another says another. Then a spirit comes forward and says, “I will entice him,” by being a lying spirit in the mouth of Ahab's prophets. And the LORD says, “You are to entice him, and you shall succeed; go out and do so” (1 Kings 22:20–22). This is a heavenly council meeting. These are spirits, not elders. God has decided that Ahab's time has come, and he lets the members of his host take part in how it is carried out.

In Daniel 7, thrones are set in place, the Ancient of Days takes his seat, and “the court sat in judgment” (Daniel 7:9–10) to decide the fate of the beastly empires. In Daniel 4, a watcher, a holy one, announces Nebuchadnezzar's humbling. The sentence is “by the decree of the watchers” (Daniel 4:17) and also “the decree of the Most High” (Daniel 4:24). So the council does not act on its own. Its members are God's agents. They carry out his decisions, but he allows them to take part in making them.

Why Would God Need a Council?

People are uncomfortable with this, and the first objection is: why would God need a council? The answer is simple: he doesn't. God needs nothing. He does not need a council any more than he needs you or needs the church.

But God delights to involve his children in what he is doing. He does it in heaven with his heavenly children, the sons of God. And he does it on earth with his sons and daughters, the church. That is all we are saying.

Is This Polytheism?

The second objection is: isn't this polytheism? No, it is not. And this is where the word Elohim has to be understood the way the biblical writers used it.

Elohim appears in the Hebrew Bible thousands of times. When you study every use, you find that the biblical writers use it for about half a dozen different kinds of beings: the God of Israel; the members of his council (Psalm 82); the gods of the nations, such as Ashtoreth and Chemosh (1 Kings 11:33); demons (Deuteronomy 32:17, where the Israelites sacrificed to shedim, to elohim they had not known); angels; and even the spirits of the human dead.

That last one settles it. In 1 Samuel 28, Saul goes to the medium at Endor and asks her to bring up Samuel. When she sees him, she says: “I see a god [elohim] coming up out of the earth” (1 Samuel 28:13). No Israelite in his right mind thought that a departed relative now had the attributes of Yahweh. Yet the dead Samuel is called elohim.

So Elohim is not a word for a set of divine attributes. That is how we moderns read the letters G-O-D. For the biblical writers, elohim was a word for residence, not rank: it described any being whose proper home is the spiritual world. The spirit world is full of elohim, just as it is full of spirits.

Yahweh lives in that world, but no other elohim is him. Here is how I put it: Yahweh is an elohim, but no other elohim is Yahweh. What makes him different? He alone is eternal, the Creator of all things

visible and invisible, sovereign, all-knowing and all-powerful. Those attributes are given only to him and denied to every other elohim. He is unique in kind. That is the theology of the Hebrew Bible, and it is not polytheism.

Does the Text Mean What It Says?

Consider how often Scripture says that the LORD is “God of gods and Lord of lords” (Deuteronomy 10:17), or that he is “a great King above all gods” (Psalm 95:3), or asks, “Who is like you, O LORD, among the gods?” (Exodus 15:11).

If the gods are not real, these statements are empty. What glory is there in saying God is greater than things that do not exist? You might as well praise him for being greater than cartoon characters. Either the text means what it says, or it is exaggerating. I choose to believe it means what it says.

When Psalm 82 confronts you, it confronts your theology. Will you choose what you prefer to believe over the text you call the Word of God? That is the choice in front of every one of us.

“There Is None Besides Me”

What about the verses that say, “there is no other besides him” (Deuteronomy 4:35)? These are not denials that other spiritual beings exist. They are statements of incomparability.

Look at the same chapter. Deuteronomy 4:19 warns Israel not to worship the sun, moon, stars and all the host of heaven, “things

that the LORD your God has allotted to all the peoples under the whole heaven." Deuteronomy 17:3 speaks of serving "other gods" and the host of heaven. Deuteronomy 29:26 says Israel served "gods whom they had not known and whom he had not allotted to them." If "none besides him" meant other gods do not exist, Deuteronomy would be contradicting itself chapter after chapter. Scripture does not contradict itself. Our thinking needs adjusting.

Here is the proof. In Isaiah 47:8, Babylon boasts, "I am, and there is no one besides me." In Zephaniah 2:15, Nineveh says the same. Was Babylon claiming that no other cities existed? Of course not. It was claiming to be beyond comparison. That is what this language means.

How Is Jesus the Son of God?

Then how can Jesus be the Son of God if there are other sons of God? You do not need this teaching to raise the question; the Old Testament already speaks of sons of God in Job 1, Job 2 and Job 38.

Look at John 3:16. Older translations say "only begotten Son." The Greek word is monogenēs. Scholars once thought it came from words meaning only and to beget. Further research showed that it comes from monos, only, and genos, kind. Monogenēs means unique, one of a kind.

Hebrews 11:17 proves it. Abraham offered up Isaac, "his only son", his monogenēs. But Isaac was not Abraham's only son; Ishmael was born first. Yet Isaac was unique: the son of promise, born to Sarah

by a supernatural act of God. So Jesus is the unique Son of God, unlike every other son of God, because he is God. Yahweh is unique among the elohim, and Jesus is God incarnate. Our theology loses nothing.

The Deuteronomy 32 Worldview

Now we come to the framework that changes how you read the whole Bible. The best place to start is not Deuteronomy, but Daniel 10.

> *The prince of the kingdom of Persia withstood me twenty-one days, but Michael, one of the chief princes, came to help me. (Daniel 10:13, ESV)*

Later the messenger says he will return to fight the prince of Persia, and the prince of Greece will come (Daniel 10:20). These princes are supernatural beings tied to geopolitical empires, and they are enemies of God and of Israel. People who love the supernatural love this passage. But have you ever asked where Daniel got this theology? Most people would say there is nothing like it in the Bible before Daniel 10. There is. It is in Deuteronomy 32.

Three Rebellions

Ask most Christians why the world is in such a mess, and they will say: the fall, Genesis 3. But an Israelite reading his Hebrew Bible, or a Jew of the New Testament era, would have given three reasons, three rebellions involving humans and supernatural beings.

The first is the fall in Eden. That starts everything. The second is Genesis 6:1–4, when the sons of God came to the daughters of men. The third is Babel. It is Babel that leads us into Deuteronomy 32.

Babel and the Sons of God

You know the story of the Tower of Babel in Genesis 11:1–9, and you will not find other gods in it. But Genesis 11 is not the only passage about Babel. Deuteronomy 32:8–9 looks back on it:

> *When the Most High gave to the nations their inheritance, when he divided mankind, he fixed the borders of the peoples according to the number of the sons of God. But the LORD's portion is his people, Jacob his allotted heritage. (Deuteronomy 32:8–9, ESV)*

When was mankind divided? At Babel. And look at the phrase: the sons of God. The ESV footnote explains that this is the reading of the Dead Sea Scrolls and of the Septuagint, the ancient Greek translation the apostles used. The scroll known as 4Q37 reads bĕnê ʾelōhîm, sons of God. Some translations, like the NIV, follow the later Hebrew text, which reads sons of Israel, and so readers never see the connection to Babel or to the sons of God elsewhere in Scripture.

What Happened at Babel

Here is the story. After the flood, God gave Noah and his sons the same mandate he gave Adam and Eve: be fruitful, multiply, fill the earth. They did the opposite. They gathered at Babel and said, “let

us build ourselves a city and a tower … lest we be dispersed over the face of the whole earth" (Genesis 11:4). In other words, lest we obey.

The tower was a ziggurat, a step-pyramid that formed part of a temple complex. Ancient people built them to bring a god down to them and keep him there. God's response was: I am not at your beck and call. I will not be tamed.

So God confused their languages and scattered the nations listed in Genesis 10. But he did it according to the number of the sons of God. He disinherited the nations and allotted them to lesser elohim, members of his heavenly host. That is why the language of Deuteronomy 4:19 and 29:26 speaks of gods God allotted to the nations.

Have you ever wondered how the world went from everyone knowing the true God to Abraham's own family worshipping other gods (Joshua 24:2)? This is the Old Testament's answer: Babel.

God Starts Again with Abraham

Then, immediately after Babel, God calls Abram out of Ur. He starts over, creating a new Eden people for himself. Israel becomes the LORD's portion (Deuteronomy 32:9).

He chooses Sarah, who cannot have children, so that the whole world will know that Israel exists because of a supernatural act of God. He makes them a kingdom of priests (Exodus 19:6) to represent him to the nations.

But God never lost interest in the nations. His promise to Abram is that through him and his seed “all the families of the earth shall be blessed” (Genesis 12:3). The nations are under judgment, but God intends to bring them back.

That is why Psalm 82 ends with this cry: “Arise, O God, judge the earth; for you shall inherit all the nations!” (Psalm 82:8). The gods of the nations will die like men, and God will take the nations back.

Israel Against the Nations, Yahweh Against the Gods

Babel frames the rest of the Old Testament. From that point on, the story is Israel against the nations and Yahweh against the gods. This is the starting point for what we call spiritual warfare.

And this is where Paul gets his vocabulary. Read his Greek Old Testament, especially Daniel 10 and Deuteronomy 32, and you find the language of principalities, powers, rulers, thrones, dominions and world rulers. What do these words have in common? They are terms of geographical rule. That is no accident.

Paul is the apostle to the nations. When he leaves Judea, he knows exactly what he is walking into. In Athens, he even echoes Deuteronomy 32 when he says that God “made from one man every nation of mankind … having determined allotted periods and the boundaries of their dwelling place” (Acts 17:26).

Pentecost: Babel Reversed

You have heard Acts 2 preached a hundred times. Now see it this way.

On the day of Pentecost, “divided tongues as of fire” rested on the disciples (Acts 2:3). The Greek word for divided, diamerizo, is the same word the Greek Old Testament uses in Deuteronomy 32:8, when the Most High divided the nations. And when the crowd heard the disciples speaking in their own languages, they were “bewildered” (Acts 2:6). That word is used in the Greek Old Testament for the confusing of languages at Babel in Genesis 11.

Coincidence? No. Jews scattered among the nations came to Jerusalem for the feast. They witnessed the coming of the Spirit, heard the story of Jesus in their own tongues, believed, and went home. God had planted witnesses in the nations. The reversal of Babel had begun.

Look at the list of places in Acts 2 runs from the east to the west, and when it reaches the Mediterranean it splits north and south, covering the same regions as the nations of Genesis 10. As you follow the book of Acts, the gospel goes to the Jew first, then to the Gentiles: Samaria, which was missing from the Acts 2 list; the Ethiopian official, who carries the gospel back to Africa; even Azotus (Acts 8:40), in old Philistine territory.

Why Paul Had to Get to Spain

Paul tells the Romans that he will see them on his way to Spain (Romans 15:24, 28). He is going to Rome in chains to appeal to Caesar, yet he speaks as though his life cannot end until he reaches Spain. Why Spain?

In the ancient world, the far west of the Mediterranean was associated with Tarshish, one of the names in the Genesis 10 table of nations. It was the last region of that table not yet reached by the gospel in Acts. Paul believed his work was not done until he had taken the gospel to the ends of the disinherited world.

You Are the New Sons and Daughters of God

Why does this matter to you? Many believers receive almost no teaching on angels, demons and the spiritual world, and when that happens, you assume it cannot be important. It is.

But look at what Scripture says about you. “To all who did receive him, who believed in his name, he gave the right to become children of God” (John 1:12). “See what kind of love the Father has given to us, that we should be called children of God” (1 John 3:1).

In the Old Testament, the holy ones are overwhelmingly members of the heavenly council. In the New Testament, the same word, usually translated saints, is used again and again of believers. You are the new sons and daughters of God, restoring what was lost through the rebellions.

In Hebrews 2:11–12, Jesus is not ashamed to call us brothers, and he says, “in the midst of the congregation I will sing your praise.” Paul tells the Corinthians, “Do you not know that we are to judge angels?” (1 Corinthians 6:3). And in Revelation, Jesus promises: “The one who conquers … I will give authority over the nations” (Revelation 2:26), and “I will grant him to sit with me on my throne” (Revelation 3:21).

Who rules the nations now? The fallen powers. Who will displace them and rule in their place? The children of God. Picture the divine council as a royal household: the King at the top, his family next, and then his servants. Believers are the family.

The Powers Are Already Defeated

Again and again, the New Testament links Jesus' resurrection and ascension with the defeat of the principalities and powers. God raised Christ and seated him “far above all rule and authority and power and dominion” (Ephesians 1:20–21). On the cross he “disarmed the rulers and authorities and put them to open shame” (Colossians 2:15). He has gone into heaven, “with angels, authorities, and powers having been subjected to him” (1 Peter 3:22).

The ascension means Jesus is Lord of heaven and earth. The authority the powers received at Babel, which they corrupted, has been withdrawn. They have no rightful authority over anyone. The only people they hold are people who do not yet know this.

That is why Paul could walk into a pagan city and say: turn from your gods. And when people feared what the gods would do, he could answer: do not fear them. They are defeated. The Most High who gave them authority has taken it back. He not only allows you to come home; he insists on it, because he became a man in Jesus, died for your sins, rose again and took his seat at the right hand.

What Spiritual Warfare Really Is

Paul links this to “the fullness of the Gentiles” (Romans 11:25–26). When the full number of the nations has come in, Israel will be awakened, and then the end will come.

So what stands in the way? I will be blunt: we do. Many believe the Great Commission is impossible. It is not. Do the arithmetic. If every believer reached one person in a year, and every new believer did the same the next year, the number of believers would double every year. Start with just 100 million faithful believers, and in seven years of doubling you would pass the entire population of the world.

So, do the powers of darkness think they can win? They are not fools. They know they cannot defeat God; in the Gospels the demons cry out, “Have you come here to torment us before the time?” (Matthew 8:29). But they know their end is tied to the fullness of the nations. So their strategy is to keep the church distracted, corrupted and conformed to the world, so that it does not do the Great Commission. Every year the church is off-mission, they remain in the field.

Hear this, because it will correct a lot of noise: spiritual warfare is not mainly shouting at demons in a room. That is showtime. Spiritual warfare is carrying out the Great Commission. Every soul brought out of the nations into the family of God is territory taken back from the powers.

The Chariots and the Horsemen

Now you can see why I chose our theme. When Elisha's servant looked at Dothan and saw only the Syrian army, he was reading the situation like a modern man: what you see is all there is. When God opened his eyes, he saw the mountain full of horses and chariots of fire (2 Kings 6:17). That was the heavenly host, the same host Micaiah saw standing around the throne.

The unseen realm is not a myth to be explained away. It is the world the Bible takes for granted. And in that world, the One who sits on the throne has already given his Son all authority in heaven and on earth (Matthew 28:18). That is why he can send you to all the nations. They that be with us are more than they that be with them.

Reading Your Bible Through the Lens of the Unseen Realm

A Framework, Not a Theory of Everything

Let me be careful here. This is not a theory of everything. It will not answer every question. But it gives you a framework, a map, a mosaic. Once you see it, you cannot unsee it. You will read a passage and ask, is this part of the bigger picture? And very often it is.

So let me teach you how to read with this lens. Here are the principles, and then some examples you can practise with.

Ten Principles for Reading

One. Ask what the original writer and his first readers assumed. Before you ask what a passage means to you, ask what it meant to them, in their world.

Two. Do not filter out the supernatural. If the text says a spirit stood before the LORD, a spirit stood before the LORD. Do not turn it into a metaphor because it makes you uncomfortable.

Three. If it's weird, it's important. The strange passages are often the doors into the centre of the story. Slow down there.

Four. Watch for council language. When you see gods, sons of God, the host of heaven, holy ones, watchers, the assembly or the council, ask whether the divine council is in view.

Five. Remember that elohim describes residence, not rank. A being called elohim lives in the spiritual realm. That does not make it equal to Yahweh. Yahweh is an elohim; no other elohim is Yahweh.

Six. Read “none besides me” as incomparability, not as a denial of existence. God is not boasting that he is greater than nothing.

Seven. Follow the geography. Nations, borders, princes, and the far places of the earth are not background scenery. From Babel onward, the map of the world is a map of spiritual conflict and of God's plan to reclaim it.

Eight. Read the Old Testament in its own world, and read the New Testament in light of the Old and of the Jewish writings between the Testaments. The apostles did not invent their vocabulary. They inherited it.

Nine. Read like a novel. Expect the Author to plant details that will come back. When a word or an image repeats, trace it.

Ten. Keep Jesus as the linchpin. The unseen realm is not a distraction from Christ. It shows you how big his victory is. Every thread leads to his throne.

Practising the Framework

Let me show you how this opens up passages you know well.

Ephesians 6:12. “For we do not wrestle against flesh and blood, but against the rulers, against the authorities, against the cosmic powers over this present darkness, against the spiritual forces of evil in the heavenly places.” Read through the Deuteronomy 32 lens, these are not vague bad feelings. They are the rebel powers that took hold of the nations, and the vocabulary is the language of territorial rule.

Matthew 28:18–19. “All authority in heaven and on earth has been given to me. Go therefore and make disciples of all nations.” Notice the therefore. Because the authority of the powers over the nations has been transferred to Jesus, he sends his people to reclaim the nations. The Great Commission is Babel in reverse.

Psalm 82:8. “Arise, O God, judge the earth; for you shall inherit all the nations!” This prayer is answered in Acts and finished in Revelation, where people from every tribe, language and nation stand before the throne (Revelation 7:9).

2 Kings 6:16–17. Elisha's servant was not given new chariots. He was given new eyes. The host was already there. That is what this framework does for your reading: the realities were always in the text; now you can see them.

Job 1 and 2. When the sons of God present themselves before the LORD, you are watching a council session. This is not a fable. It is a

window into how Scripture pictures God's rule over heaven and earth.

Questions and Answers on the Unseen Realm

How to Use This Section

These are questions scholars, pastors and serious students commonly raise about the divine council and the supernatural worldview of Scripture. Where a question is debated among faithful scholars, I tell you so.

Questions on the Divine Council

Isn't belief in a divine council just polytheism?

No. Polytheism believes in many gods of the same kind, competing for power. The Bible teaches one God who is unique in kind: eternal, uncreated, all-powerful and sovereign. Every other elohim is created by him and answerable to him (Nehemiah 9:6; Colossians 1:16). Remember the key: Yahweh is an elohim, but no other elohim is Yahweh.

Are the gods of Psalm 82 human judges?

That is the popular view, but it does not fit the text. Psalm 89:5–7 places the same council of the sons of God in the heavens. Psalm 82:7 says they will die like men, which would mean nothing if they

were already men. And Jesus' use of the psalm in John 10 only works if the sons of God are more than human.

Why would an all-powerful God use a council?

He doesn't need one. He chooses to involve his children in his work, in heaven and on earth. The council is not a sign of need. It is a sign of the kind of God he is: a Father who shares his rule with his family.

Are angels and the sons of God the same thing?

They are not identical. Angel, in Hebrew mal'ak, is a job description: messenger. Elohim describes the nature of a being and where it lives: the spiritual realm. Sons of God describes family and rank in God's household. The same being can be described in different ways, but not every term means the same thing. The sons of God belong to the higher tier of the council, and angels as messengers serve at a lower tier.

Questions on Specific Passages

Why do some Bibles say “sons of Israel” in Deuteronomy 32:8?

Because they follow the later Masoretic Hebrew text. The older evidence, a Dead Sea Scroll of Deuteronomy (4Q37) and the Septuagint, points to sons of God. Most scholars today consider sons of God the original reading, which is why the ESV, NRSV and NET use it. It also makes better sense: Israel did not exist at Babel, so dividing the nations according to the number of the sons of Israel is hard to explain.

Who are the sons of God in Genesis 6:1–4?

I hold the view, held by most ancient Jewish and early Christian interpreters, that they were rebellious heavenly beings who crossed the boundary between heaven and earth. Look at 2 Peter 2:4–5 and Jude 6, which speak of angels who sinned and did not keep their proper domain, in the context of the days of Noah. Others in the church have read the passage as the line of Seth or as human kings. This is a debated question, and you should know the options.

Who is the satan in Job 1 and 2?

In Hebrew the word has the definite article: ha-satan, the adversary. It describes a role in the council, something like a prosecutor or accuser, and we should be cautious about simply reading the later, fully developed New Testament picture of the devil back into Job. Other scholars identify him directly with the devil. Either way, notice what matters most: he can do nothing without the LORD's permission (Job 1:12; 2:6).

Who is the Angel of the LORD?

This is one of the most important questions in the Old Testament. In passages like Genesis 48:15–16, Exodus 3:2–6 and Exodus 23:20–21, the Angel of the LORD speaks as God, is identified with God, and carries God's Name within him, yet he is distinguished from the God who sends him. Here we see a visible, embodied Yahweh alongside the invisible Yahweh in heaven, a pattern that prepares us for the Word who was with God and was God (John

1:1). Many Christians throughout history have seen the pre-incarnate Christ in this figure.

Questions on the Nations and Spiritual Warfare

Does every nation have a territorial spirit over it today?

Daniel 10 and Deuteronomy 32 show that, in the biblical worldview, rebel powers were associated with the nations. But their authority has been withdrawn through the resurrection and ascension of Jesus (Ephesians 1:20–22; Colossians 2:15). They still oppose the gospel, but they have no rightful claim. Scripture does not give us a map of named territorial spirits to chase.

Then should we spend our time binding territorial spirits?

My answer is clear: spiritual warfare is fulfilling the Great Commission. Pray, yes. Resist the devil, yes (James 4:7). But the powers lose ground when people from the nations come into the family of God. Theatrics are not the battle. Evangelism and discipleship are.

What will happen to the gods of the nations?

Psalm 82:7 says they will die like men. Isaiah 24:21 says, “On that day the LORD will punish the host of heaven, in heaven, and the kings of the earth, on the earth.” Their judgment is certain, and Revelation shows its completion.

Questions About Us

Will believers really judge angels?

Yes. Paul says so plainly in 1 Corinthians 6:3, and Jesus promises those who overcome a share in his throne and authority over the nations (Revelation 2:26–27; 3:21). Glorified believers replace the fallen powers in God's council and household. That is our destiny.

Does this framework change the gospel?

No. Anyone can read the Bible and understand who Jesus is and how to be saved. The unseen realm does not change the gospel. It shows you how vast it is: Christ has not only forgiven your sins; he has defeated every power that ever held the nations captive, and he is bringing you into his family to reign with him.

Why have I never heard this in church?

Because we read the Bible through modern filters and through our traditions, and we pass over the passages that make us uncomfortable. The answer is not to be ashamed. It is to go back to the text and read it as if for the first time.

Where should I start?

Read Psalm 82, Psalm 89:5–7, Deuteronomy 32:8–9, Daniel 10, 1 Kings 22:19–23, Acts 2 and Ephesians 1:15–23 side by side, slowly, aloud, and with others. Test everything against the text.

Acknowledgement

The teaching, framework and much of the material in this session are drawn from the published work and recorded teaching of the late Dr Michael S. Heiser, scholar of Hebrew and the ancient Near

East, especially The Unseen Realm: Recovering the Supernatural Worldview of the Bible. Scripture quotations marked ESV are from the English Standard Version.

THE CHARIOTS AND THE HORSEMEN

Closing Remarks

From the Jordan to Dothan

We began this conference at the Jordan, with Elisha crying out as his master was taken from him: “My father, my father, the chariot of Israel, and the horsemen thereof.” We end on the mountain at Dothan, with a servant whose eyes have been opened.

In between, we have walked through a library. We have seen that the Bible is one unified story that leads to Jesus. We have learned to read its narrative, its poetry and its prose. We have walked through the law, the wisdom of Solomon, the Psalms, the prophets, the parables of Jesus, the letters of the apostles and the visions of Revelation. We have tested the Bible's history and found that it stands. And we have stepped into the unseen realm, the world the biblical writers took for granted.

None of this was given to make you better at Bible trivia. It was given so that you would see.

What You Now Carry

You now know that your Bible is not a random collection of verses. It is an intelligently designed story, and every part of it connects to the whole. You know that its history can bear the weight of honest

questions. And you know that it was written by men whose eyes were open to a realm most of us have been trained to ignore.

You can no longer read 2 Kings 6 the way you read it before. The horses and chariots of fire are not decoration. They are the host of heaven. And the One who commands that host has given his Son all authority in heaven and on earth (Matthew 28:18). That is why we do not have to fear the powers of darkness. Their authority has been taken from them. Ours has been given to us.

Go Back to the Book

So here is my charge to you. Go back to the Book.

Read it slowly. Read it aloud, day and night, the way Psalm 1 describes. Read whole books, not just favourite verses. Read it with other people, and argue about it, and pray about it. When you come to a strange passage, do not run past it. Stop there. If it's weird, it's important. Let the Bible interpret itself, and you will find that the Bible begins to read you.

Dead Raisers

When Elisha was dead and buried, a dead man thrown into his tomb touched his bones and stood up alive (2 Kings 13:21). The life of God on that prophet outlasted him.

That is the kind of people I want us to be: people so soaked in the Word, and so aware of the God who rules the unseen realm, that life flows out of us into dead places. Dead faith. Dead homes. Dead

cities. Nations held captive by powers that Christ has already defeated.

This is what spiritual warfare really looks like. Not theatre. Not noise. It is carrying this Word to the nations, one life at a time, until the fullness of the Gentiles has come in. Every soul that comes home to the Father is ground taken back.

A Prayer for Open Eyes

Let me close the way Elisha did, by praying for you:

> *"LORD, I pray thee, open his eyes, that he may see."*
>
> **2 KINGS 6:17**

Father, thank you for your Word. Thank you that it is true, that it has stood through the centuries, and that it leads us to Jesus. Open our eyes to see what is already true: that the mountain is full of your horses and chariots of fire round about us. Deliver us from fear. Make us a people who know your Word, love your Word, and carry it to the nations. Let your life flow through us into every dead place. In the name of Jesus, Lord of heaven and earth. Amen.

Go in this confidence: they that be with us are more than they that be with them.

God bless you.

Vwakpor Efuetanu
Lead Pastor, Grace Edge Ministry (Dead Raisers)

Our **Pastor**

Pastor Vwakpor Efuetanu is the Lead Pastor of Grace Edge Ministries, Dead Raisers, and the father of the vision of a Billion Dead Raisers.

He leads a team of zealous and committed sons who are sold out for the cause of the Word and the Spirit.

He carries a mandate to raise a people of fire in every nation and clan. He founded Dead Raisers in 2016 with a few members and with the vision of a billion men sworn to the course of Dead Raisers which is the course of Christ, through preaching, miracles, prayers, demonstration of the Spirit's gifts, and hard-core loyalty to the man, the message, and the mandate.

He is devoted to the gospel of Christ, a prophetic deliverance minister seasoned with light and fire for many generations to come.

He holds services three times every week, as well as numerous other meetings and gatherings throughout the year—such as Word Conferences, Homecoming Conferences, Healing Meetings, Hotspot Meetings, Area Crusades, market and village crusades, and more.

He runs a prophetic school for spiritual advancement via the secular, called The Elites' Class, and consistently inspires his followers to pursue persistent excellence and influence in all aspects of life.

He is currently based in Benin City, married to Pastor Funmilayo Efuetanu.



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